

Online appendix for Democratic Deepening or Elite Persistence? How Local Elites Adapt to Electoral Reform in Rural India

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A Qualitative data collection description

This section details over 2 years of qualitative data collection that contribute to this project, both in theory-building and theory-testing.

A.1 Theory-building

From March 2018 to March 2020, I conducted theory-building, exploratory qualitative work that led to the development of my theory and hypotheses.

During this time period, I visited 47 village councils, 11 district offices, and 15 block offices in the western state of Maharashtra. I employed a combination of interview-based, observational, and shadow-based research techniques. I visited village councils (*gram panchayats*) in 12 districts across Maharashtra; district offices (*zilla parishad*) in 11 districts (Pune, Solapur, Satara, Ahmednagar, Nashik, Aurangabad, Nanded, Washim, Amravati, Jalgaon, Nagpur); and block offices (*panchayat samiti*) in 15 blocks. On average, I visited each district and block office once. I visited each village council between 1 and 5 times.¹

While visiting district and block offices, I interviewed government officials and politicians who were present. This included conducting interviews about the *de jure* institutional design of the village council, as well as about the *de facto* functioning of the village council. Visits to village councils included a range of interactions. In every village council, at a minimum, I interviewed and shadowed the village council president for an entire day. In addition, in some village councils, I was also able to interview the vice president, village secretary, active ward members, village citizens, and observe the monthly meeting, village meeting, and election proceedings. All in all, I conducted approximately 150 interviews, and observed 20 monthly meetings.²

In order to understand the experiences of village council presidents, it was important to combine both interview-based and observational methods. First, it is clear that it is important to interview the council president directly, in order to have a first-hand account of her own experience, as she understands it. Yet, social desirability bias may be particularly acute for public officials, as they may have incentives to report only information that conforms with the legal expectations of the institutions in which they serve. One way I sought to triangulate information was through additional interviews with key stakeholders (vice president, village secretary, ward members, village notables), allowing me to get at other players' perceptions of the village council president's authority. Perhaps even more importantly, shadowing and observation were key to supplementing my understanding of the presidents' experience within the institution of the village council. Spending multiple days observing the council president complete her tasks allowed me to observe her interactions with others in the council. Further, sitting in on village council monthly meetings

¹All communications were conducted in Marathi. At times I went and joint-interviewed and observed alongside a research associate, and at times I went alone. I (and research associates, if present) always stayed in the district headquarters town or city, and made day trips to the offices or village councils.

²Monthly meetings were trickier to be able to observe logistically, since they only occur once per month on a given day. My ability to attend hinged on being in the region on the day that the meeting was planned. Even when I had plans to attend, it was not infrequent for me to show up for a monthly meeting only to learn that it had been postponed for various reasons.

allowed direct behavioral observations of the president’s authority, and barriers to it, in one of the key decision-making arenas of the village council. Taken together, these interview and observation-based techniques allowed me to triangulate information in order to develop a detailed picture of the reality in each village council.

Before going to a village council, I called the council president’s number (obtained via public records kept either online or at the block office) beforehand to introduce myself, the research project, and ask permission to come for an interview in her village. Upon arriving to the village at the time and place given by the village council president, I would re-introduce myself (and if applicable, my research associate) and re-explain my research interests. At times, the interviews took place in the village council office building, and other times it took place in the home of the council president. Though the interviews were largely carried out in private, it was not uncommon for office clerks to stop by and ask about the reason for the interview, if it was carried out in the village council office. Once I had completed the initial interview with the council president, I asked permission to interview the village secretary, vice president, village notables, as well as to attend any village functions, council meetings, and observe the president during one day of work. Interviews with village secretaries either took place in the block office or in the village council office. Interviews with vice president were conducted either at their home or in the village council office. Interviews with village notables were conducted either at their location of work (school, health center, day care, etc.) or at their home. None of the participants of the any of the interviews were present for the interviews of others. Each interview lasted between 30 minutes and 1 hour, and took place between the hours of 8:00 a.m. and 5:00 p.m.

In addition to interviews, I supplemented my data collection efforts with observational research. I did this through shadowing the village council president in the village and village council, observing her routines, actions, and interactions. I also attended village council meetings, where I sat in the back of the room and observed the interpersonal interactions and decision-making processes of the council. Village council meetings include long agendas of many decisions to be made, and so participants must proceed with focus and efficiency in order to make it through the agenda. Thus, the focused participation of the attendees, and the long duration of the meetings, made me believe that any social desirability bias related to my presence would decrease over time as participants became engaged in the proceedings of the meeting. Plus, I would only attend meetings after several days spent in and around a village council, so most participants in the meeting at that point were accustomed to my presence. Moreover, I did not feel that my presence biased the actions of meeting participants. If this were the case, one would expect that social desirability bias would lead participants to act in a legally appropriate way during deliberation (specifically, that they would let the president preside); yet, this is not what I found.

A.2 Theory-testing

In the summer of 2022 and 2024, I conducted qualitative theory-testing fieldwork focused on comparing villages with indirect and direct elections. The underlying theory for this part of the project was developed iteratively in the prior part of the project, with significant input from anonymous reviewers further shaping it in the spring of 2024. In 2022, I interviewed 16 council presidents (from 8 councils) in Pune and Amravati district. They were contacted

according to the electoral regime and quota status of the council. In 2024, I conducted interviews and shadowing in 7 village councils in Pune district. All councils were from the same block, selected to be representative's of the state's population and literacy rates. The first council in this batch (Council 1) was selected randomly, and the others were located within geographic proximity (within the same block) and matched to this council. These councils were selected to maximize control on structural variables (population numbers, administrative boundaries, reservation status of the president seat) while allowing controlled comparisons across election regime status. The tables below summarize the qualitative research.

Table A.1: Politician interviews (2022)

Council	Politician	Election type	Date, place	Time
A	President #5	Indirect, shared	23-06-22, President's home	30 min
A	President #3	Indirect, shared	25-06-22, President's home	30 min
A	President #1	Indirect, shared	25-06-22, Council office	60 min
A	President #1	Indirect, shared	03-07-22, Council office	45 min
A	Vice president	Indirect, shared	03-07-22, Council office	1 hour
A	President	n/a	03-07-22, Respondent's home	20 min
B	President #1	Indirect, shared	23-06-22, Council office	50 min
B	President #2	Indirect, shared	23-06-22, President's home	25 min
B	President #3	Indirect, shared	23-06-22, President's home	35 min
C	President	Direct, not shared	25-06-22, President's home	45 min
C	President	Indirect, not shared	09-07-22, President's home	75 min
D	President #1	Indirect, shared	25-06-22, President's home	1 hour
E	President #1	Indirect, shared	25-06-22, President's home	30 min
F	President	Direct, not shared	10-07-22, Council office	45 min
G	President	Direct, not shared	10-07-22, President's home	35 min

H	President	Direct, not shared	20-05-22, President's home	45 min
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Table A.2: Controlled comparisons (2024)

Council	President reservation	Election	Respondent	Date, place	Time
1	No caste, no gender	Indirect	President # 1	22-07-24, Home	37 min
			Vice President	23-07-24, Home	1 hour
			Female citizen # 1	23-07-24, Council	18 min
			Female citizen # 2	08-08-24, Workplace	17 min
			Female citizen # 3	08-08-24, Home	17 min
			Male citizen # 1	22-07-24, Home	22 min
			Male citizen # 2	23-07-24, Council	1 hour
			Male citizen # 3	08-08-24, Council	15 min
			Influential villager # 1	23-07-24, Home	32 min
			Influential villager # 2	08-08-24, Pune	35 min
			Village clerk	23-07-24, Council	60 min
2	No caste, no gender	Indirect	President # 1	09-08-24, Council	35 min
			Bureaucrat	09-08-24, Council	25 min
			Female citizen # 1	09-08-24, Council	25 min
			Female citizen # 2	09-08-24, Home	25 min
			Female citizen # 3	09-08-24, Workplace	25 min
			Male citizen # 1	09-08-24, Home	37 min
			Male citizen # 2	09-08-24, Home	25 min
			Male citizen # 3	13-08-24, Home	36 min
			Influential villager # 1	09-08-24, Home	35 min
			Influential villager # 2	13-08-24, Home	22 min
			Village clerk	13-08-24, Temple	20 min
3	No caste, no gender	Direct	President	14-08-24, Council	1.5 hours
			Bureaucrat	14-08-24, Council	30 min
			Female citizen # 1	14-08-24, Home	12 min
			Male citizen # 1	14-08-24, Home	25 min
			Male citizen # 2	14-08-24, Home	30 min
			Male citizen # 3	14-08-24, Home	30 min
			Influential villager # 1	14-08-24, Home	45 min
			Influential villager # 2	14-08-24, Home	40 min
			Village clerk	14-08-24, Council	25 min
4	No caste, no gender	Direct	President	15-08-24, Council	50 min
			Bureaucrat	15-08-24, Council	30 min
			Female citizen # 1	15-08-24, Home	15 min
			Male citizen # 1	15-08-24, Village center	35 min
			Village clerk	15-08-24, Council	25 min
			Gram sabha	15-08-24, Council	2 hours
5	SC Woman	Indirect	President	12-08-24, Council	25 min
			Female citizen # 1	12-08-24, Workplace	10 min
			Female citizen # 2	12-08-24, Workplace	18 min

			Male citizen # 1	12-08-24, Home	20 min
			Male citizen # 2	12-08-24, Workplace	35 min
			Council member	12-08-24, Council	25 min
			Village clerk	12-08-24, Council	25 min
6	SC Woman	Direct	President	28-08-24, Home	40 min
			Vice president	28-08-24, Home	25 min
			Bureaucrat	28-08-24, Council	15 min
			Female citizen # 1	28-08-24, Workplace	10 min
			Female citizen # 2	28-08-24, Workplace	15 min
			Male citizen # 1	28-08-24, Council	25 min
			Male citizen # 2	28-08-24, Home	15 min
			Male citizen # 3	28-08-24, Workplace	18 min
			Influential villager # 1	28-08-24, Home	35 min
			Gram sabha	28-08-24, Council	1 hour
7	SC Woman	Direct	President	01-10-24, Home	30 min
			Council member	01-10-24, Home	25 min
			Influential villager # 1	03-10-24, Home	15 min
			Female citizen # 1	01-10-24, Home	40 min
			Male citizen # 1	01-10-24, Home	25 min

I also interviewed civil society members, party workers, village bureaucrats, government officials, and higher-level politicians across 6 districts from 2022 to 2025. These interviews served 3 purposes. First, I sought to understand the logic of the policy changes in 2017 from indirect to direct elections, and in 2020 back to indirect elections. Second, I wanted to gather evidence on what these actors thought of the different systems based on what they've seen. Third, I sought to understand the rationale behind the timing of council elections in Maharashtra.

Table A.3: Officials, bureaucrats, and civil society member interviews

District	Location	Person	Date, place	Duration
Konkan	Mumbai	NCP president, former CM	26-06-22, Their office	1 hour
Konkan	Navi Mumbai	President of NGO	27-06-22, Their office	2 hours
Konkan	Navi Mumbai	Former State Election Commissioner	27-06-22, Their office	1 hour
Konkan	Navi Mumbai	NGO field staff	27-06-22, Their office	1 hour
Pune	Pune	Village council election department official	11-07-22, Collector's office	1 hour
Pune	Paud Panchayat Samiti	Village bureaucrat	21-06-22, BDO's office	30 min
Pune	Village council	Gram sevak	23-06-22	35 min
Pune	Pune city	High-level bureaucrat	17-06-22, 16-06-22 , ZP	1 hour
Pune	Village council	Gram sevak	21-06-22	30 min
Pune	Pune city	High-level bureaucrat	16-06-22, collector's office	30 min
Aurangabad	Aurangabad	High-level bureaucrat	20-06-22, ZP	45 min
Amravati	Amravati	ZP village council department official	20-05-22, ZP	35 min
Aurangabad	Aurangabad	High-level bureaucrat	20-06-22, ZP	30 min
Pune	Pune city	High-level bureaucrat	22-06-22, collector's office	35 min
NA	Jodhpur	High-level bureaucrat MH Election Commission	25-07-24, Symposium	60 min
NA	Jodhpur	High-level bureaucrat MH Election Commission	25-07-24, Symposium	60 min
Jalgaon	Jalgaon city	Party leader Congress party	29-08-24, Home	60 min
Yavatmal	Remote	Party leader BJP	19-03-25, Remote	45 min
Yavatmal	Remote	Party leader BJP	18-03-25, Remote	45 min

B Data from quasi-experimental observational design

B.1 Dataset 1: Large-scale survey across rural Maharashtra

B.1.1 Sampling and survey design

604 village councils across 5 districts of the state of Maharashtra were sampled, approximately 120 villages in each of 5 districts. The survey and sampling design were developed and implemented jointly with Rachel Brulé and Simon Chauchard.

Stratification on president reservations for gender and caste (for SC, OBC, and open sarpanches) was done as well as with the gender of the gram sevak (the main village bureaucrat). Equal samples of village councils were targeted with each combination of these 3 traits. This means that we selected $3 \times 2 \times 2 = 12$ different types of village councils, and aimed to do so equally within each district. This meant oversampling councils reserved for OBCs and SCs, given that in Maharashtra 27% of the president seats within each block council in each electoral period are to be reserved for members of the OBCs, while another 13% are reserved for SCs. This also meant oversampling councils with female gram sevaks, which are approximated to be 20% of the total sampling frame. Finally, councils reserved for STs are excluded (7% of total councils in Maharashtra).

The sample included 5 districts spread across four regions of Maharashtra. Given the focus on rural areas, the administrative region with the most dense urban center in India – Mumbai/Konkan – was excluded. Out of the remaining regions, we planned to select districts with relatively high proportions of SC population (to enable oversampling of SC reservations, which are allocated based on population proportions), and relative proximity to urban centers (to assist in our oversampling of female gram sevaks, who are more likely to be sent to GPs at closer proximity to urban centers than to remote locales). We excluded from our sampling frame districts with above average proportions of STs (greater than 10%) to ensure that our exclusion of ST reserved seats (allocated by population proportion, as are SC reservations) would not significantly bias our sample given the district population distribution.

The five districts selected include Solapur (Paschim region), Pune (Paschim region), Aurangabad (Marathwada region), Amravati (Vidarbha region) and Ahmednagar (Nashik region). In each district we then identified the five talukas (subdistricts) with the largest absolute numbers of “rare” combinations within each district (in practice OBC and SC presidents paired with female gram sevaks).

Once these were selected, we next chose as close to 24 village councils as possible in each taluka (since the total district $N = 24 \times 5 = 120$). Since the blocking strategy described above implies 12 different categories of village councils to be equally sampled, we simply aimed at this stage to select 2 village councils in each of the 12 categories to reach this total of 24 village councils per taluka. If and when we were able to choose between more than two village councils in a given category and taluka, we selected randomly. If and when there were fewer than two village councils in a given category within a taluka, we first attempted to replace the “missing village councils” by oversampling similar GPs (GPs from the same category) in another selected taluka in the same district. If and when we were unable to do so, we replaced these missing village councils with “open” category village councils both

with male and female gram sevaks within the taluka. As we proceeded, we made sure to minimize the difference in the number of village councils sampled across talukas.

The design included 10 surveys in each village council. We interviewed: the village council president; vice president; village council bureaucrat; the president, vice president, and bureaucrat jointly in a facilitated discussion; and a sample of 6 gender- and caste-based citizens. Data collection occurred from 2020-2022 in 604 village councils. Sampling was orthogonal to direct election status (this was not the purpose of the data collection at the time).

B.1.2 Council president descriptives

Each village council included an in-depth, private interview with the village council president. This interview included questions about their background, political history, perceptions of their authority as well as reports of others' interference in village council affairs.

Table B.1 provides information on key characteristics for the presidents of the 604 villages in the sample: the president's reservation status, gender, caste, and wealth measured in terms of whether or not they own land that is titled in their name, own a *pacca* house, and a three or four-wheeler vehicle.

Table B.1: President characteristics in sample

Variable	Mean	SD
Reserved SC	0.321	0.467
Reserved OBC	0.310	0.463
Reserved Women	0.483	0.500
Sarpanch is Male	0.419	0.494
Sarpanch is Maratha	0.270	0.444
Owens Land (Own Name)	0.394	0.489
Lives in Pacca House	0.551	0.498
Owens Three/Four Wheeler	0.214	0.410

B.1.3 Sampling citizens

The citizen survey targeted 6 key informants in each village council.

Sampling strategy: while the field team interviewed available citizens, they had to work with strict constraints regarding the key demographic characteristics of the group of individuals they interviewed. Namely, they by design had to include a gender-balanced list of 2 SCs (1 male, 1 female) and 4 non-SCs (2 male, 2 female). As a result, our sample of 6 citizens within each village is balanced on gender, and roughly balanced on caste (or at least inclusive of lower castes). In order to ensure we have a comparable list of citizens across sampled villages, we restricted our sample universe to include individuals who occupy the following roles: School teacher, Anganwadi worker, PDS Shopkeeper, Self Help Group leader, Doctor/Nurse/Public Health Center worker, Party worker, Informal Leader (ex. Religious

leader or caste panchayat leader), Kotwal, government employees residing in the GP (but not working for the GP), and Talathi (village revenue officer).

This strategy enables us to achieve a gender-balanced subset of people who are truly knowledgeable about local politics, representing both ends of the caste-based power spectrum: disadvantaged SC citizens, and more socially "mainstream" citizens. Table B.2 below provides details on the key characteristics of our citizen sample.

As seen from these numbers, the sample is perfectly gender-balanced and includes a diversity of caste profiles and occupations. Citizens also emerge as relatively well-off (as per ownership of smartphones and/or vehicles) and individuals that do spend much of their time in public, and in relative proximity to the village council. Additionally, a majority of them has prior political experience, broadly defined, which makes it indeed likely that they are the types of individuals within the village that would have information about the inner workings of the village council.

The variables from Table B.2 are constructed in the following manner.

- Female: 1 if the respondent self-identified as female, 0 otherwise.
- SC: 1 if the respondent self-identified as belonging to SC (scheduled castes), 0 otherwise.
- OBC: 1 if the respondent self-identified as belonging to OBC (other backward classes), 0 otherwise.
- GEN: 1 if the respondent self-identified as belonging to GEN (general category), 0 otherwise.
- ST: 1 if the respondent self-identified as belonging to ST (scheduled tribes), 0 otherwise.
- Education: The respondent's self-reported education attainment, where 0 is never attended school, 1 is first class, and 14 is post-graduate education.
- Age: The respondent's self-reported age (in years).
- Occupation: The respondent's self-reported occupation, from the list of options stated above.
- Has prior political experience: 1 if the respondent self-identified as having had prior political experience, 0 otherwise. Political experience is broadly defined as "experience in politics, social work, or public activity."
- Muslim: 1 if the respondent self-identified as Muslim, 0 otherwise.
- Hindu: 1 if the respondent self-identified as Hindu, 0 otherwise.
- Lives in village: 1 if the respondent reports living in one of the villages of the village council, 0 otherwise.
- Monthly wage: The respondent's self-reported monthly earnings, in Indian rupees.
- Has a vehicle: 1 if the respondent reports owning a vehicle, 0 otherwise.

Table B.2: Citizen characteristics in sample

Variable	Mean	SD
Female	0.500	0.500
SC	0.197	0.398
OBC	0.380	0.485
GEN	0.387	0.487
ST	0.036	0.187
Education	10.525	2.997
Age	42.666	11.623
School teacher	0.080	0.271
Anganwadi worker	0.145	0.352
Arogya sevika	0.067	0.250
PDS shopkeeper	0.041	0.198
SHG leader	0.070	0.256
Doctor	0.016	0.126
Party worker	0.092	0.289
PHD worker	0.042	0.201
Kotwal	0.020	0.140
Government employee	0.074	0.262
Talathi	0.004	0.062
SHG president	0.078	0.268
Informal leader	0.074	0.261
Previous council member	0.107	0.310
Previous vice president	0.034	0.182
Previous president	0.056	0.230
Prior political experience	0.573	0.495
Muslim	0.041	0.199
Hindu	0.881	0.323
Lives in village	0.922	0.268
Monthly wage (INR)	14115.706	27641.152
Has a vehicle	0.779	0.415
Has a smartphone	0.713	0.452
Hours spent outside in a day	6.019	3.032
Time to council office (hours)	0.153	0.172

- Has a smartphone: 1 if the respondent reports owning a smartphone, 0 otherwise.
- Hours spent in public in a day: The number of hours the respondent reports spending in public per day.

- Time to council office: The amount of time (in hours) it takes for the respondent to reach the village council office from their home.

B.1.4 Description of the group meeting structure & survey

The group meeting survey involves a traditional survey as well as close observations by multiple members of our gender-balanced two-person survey team. This requires the research team to gather in the same location (in the village council office) three top decision-makers in local governance: the gram sevak (appointed government bureaucrat), vice president (elected member of the village council who is appointed to be the second-in command-of the council) and the president (the head of the council), *after they have each been individually interviewed*, at a time agreed upon in advance by all.

The group meeting is meant to approximate the dynamics of the *masik sabha*, which is a monthly meeting held with only members of the village council (the elected village council with one appointed government bureaucrat). This is the most relevant forum for core governance decision-making related to the financial and policy-relevant administration of the village council and the village more broadly. Much like our group meeting, the *masik sabha* is not open to the public; this is where village council members make decisions about the council’s budget and consequent policies. As such, it is an essential meeting for decision-making with real policy implications.

Compared to the more extensively studied *gram sabha*, a public village meeting that occurs 2 to 4 times per year, we find the *masik sabha* to be comparatively more significant because of its content, frequency, and context. Specifically, the *masik sabha* is where *most* gram panchayat decisions are actually made related to budget spending and to the allocation of contracts; it is the local government meeting that occurs most regularly; and it is a non-public context limited to village council members. Indeed, while general policy preferences of villagers are discussed in the *gram sabha*, specific policy prerogatives and fiscal implementation processes are developed and decided upon by the village council members in the *masik sabha*.

In the lead-up to the group meeting, the research team proceeds as such: all three participants are individually approached (by phone) by the research team and asked to participate in a private, individual interview; at the end of this individual interview, they are then asked to participate in a “discussion during which the research team will be collecting data on the development priorities of the village and on the role that the different actors play in this process.” The group meeting simulates the structure of a typical *masik sabha* in the way that the meeting had a clear set of priorities, an agenda, and the opportunity for contribution and discussion of all members - all features of the actual monthly meeting.

B.2 Dataset 2: Administrative census of Pune district village councils

I collected and digitized administrative election data during the summer of 2022 for the census of over 1300 village councils in Pune district. This consisted of digitizing a folder of standardized Marathi government documents for each village council. This dataset represents a cross-section of the status of all village councils in the district at the time of data collection.

Historical records unrelated to the current term of each village council (for example, records about the term one cycle before the current term) are not kept by the district administration. Thus, it was only possible to access a village council’s election records for the ongoing term during which data collection was taking place.

B.2.1 The digitization process

Each village council’s folder was standardized in its contents. Over the course of 5 weeks, I and two research assistants manually entered the data from the contents of each village council’s folder. Files were organized in cabinets according to administrative blocks. In order to avoid systematic coder bias, we flipped a coin each day to determine which cabinet each coder would work on (that way, each coder did not systematically work on certain blocks, thus if there are coder-specific fixed effects in coding mistakes, they are likely to be randomly distributed.) In addition, I randomly selected 3 village council files from the piles that each coder was working on at the end of each day to cross-check for data-entry errors and correct any mistakes. I did not routinely uncover data-entry errors during this exercise, giving me confidence in the training and capacities of the coders.

B.3 Outcome description from observational design

This section details each outcome from the observational design analyzed in the main paper, its construction, justification, and data source.

B.3.1 Main outcomes: *De facto* authority

Behavioral measures:

1. **Citizen reports president leads village events.** Village citizens’ response to “Think about this village. At inaugural events or programs who tends to be the head? This might mean: who delivers the speech?”
 - **Procedure:** This was asked to citizens during the citizen survey
 - **Coding:** binary measure coded 1 when the interviewee named the sarpanch, 0 otherwise.
 - **Rationale:** this measure provides us with an assessment of the sarpanch’s behaviors and ability and/or willingness to represent the village in a village-wide meeting, as assessed by a local actor with knowledge of the gram panchayat’s affairs.
 - **Data source:** Citizen survey
2. **Citizen nominated president as village representative to bureaucrat.** Village citizens’ response to “Suppose next month there will be a meeting with the Block Development Officer in which decisions about how to resolve your village’s most urgent development problems will be made. You get to nominate one person to go and represent your village’s interests in the meeting. This can be anyone. Of course, this is

by law something that falls within the duties of the sarpanch. Who would you like to nominate? We're collecting nominations from villagers."

- **Procedure:** This was asked to citizens during the citizen survey
- **Coding:** binary measure coded 1 when the interviewee named the sarpanch, 0 otherwise.
- **Rationale:** the measure provides us with a reputational assessment of the sarpanch's ability and/or willingness to represent the village to the most important bureaucratic actor, as assessed by a local actor with knowledge of the gram panchayat's affairs.
- **Data source:** Citizen survey

3. **Proportion of time president spoke in discussion.** For what approximate percentage of the overall discussion did the sarpanch speak?

- **Procedure:** This was coded at the end of the group survey, about the entirety of the discussion.
- **Coding:** continuous measure 0-1, based on the two enumerators' joint assessment.
- **Rationale:** the measure provides us with a general indicator of the sarpanch's degree of voice in the village council.
- **Data source:** Group survey

Perception-based measures:

4. **President self-perception as main decision-maker in monthly meeting.** Response to "Think of the last masik sabha that was held. How were decisions taken in that masik sabha?"

- **Procedure:** This was asked to sarpanch during the sarpanch survey
- **Coding:** binary measure coded 1 when the interviewee said "I decide", 0 otherwise.
- **Rationale:** the measure provides us with a reputational self-assessment of the sarpanch's influence on decision-making, as assessed by a local actor with knowledge of the gram panchayat's affairs.
- **Data source:** President survey

5. **President perceived as most influential in discussion.** Response to "Out of all the participants in the group interview, who did you think was the most influential?"

- **Procedure:** This was jointly coded by the two enumerators at the end of the group survey, about the entirety of the discussion.
- **Coding:** binary measure coded 1 when the sarpanch was deemed the most influential, 0 otherwise.
- **Rationale:** the measure provides us with a general indicator of the sarpanch's degree of participation and influence in the village council.
- **Data source:** Group survey

B.3.2 Formal and informal elite capture outcomes

Formal capture.

1. Proportion land held by president's caste in village.

- **Procedure:** Gram sevak's response to, "On average approximately what proportion of land does the sarpanch's jati own in this GP's villages?"
- **Coding:** measure from 0-1 indicating the average proportion of land in the entire village (village council area) held by people in the president's caste group.
- **Rationale:** the measure provides us with a general indicator of the president's caste dominance in the village.
- **Data source:** Gram sevak survey

2. President Maratha.

- **Procedure:** Coded 1 if president self-reports as Maratha, 0 otherwise.
- **Coding:** measure with values 0 or 1 indicating whether the president is Maratha or not.
- **Rationale:** the measure provides us with a general indicator of the president's caste dominance in the village.
- **Data source:** President survey

3. President owns *pacca* house.

- **Procedure:** Coded 1 if president self-reports owning a *pacca* house, 0 otherwise.
- **Coding:** measure with values 0 or 1 indicating whether the president owns a *pacca* house.
- **Rationale:** the measure provides us with a general indicator of the president's wealth in the village.
- **Data source:** President survey

4. President owns three/four wheeler.

- **Procedure:** Coded 1 if president self-reports owning a car or three-wheeler vehicle, 0 otherwise.
- **Coding:** measure with values 0 or 1 indicating whether the president owns a three- or four-wheeler vehicle.
- **Rationale:** the measure provides us with a general indicator of the president's wealth in the village.
- **Data source:** President survey

5. President landed.

- **Procedure:** Coded 1 if president self-reports owning land on their own name, 0 otherwise.
- **Coding:** measure with values 0 or 1 indicating whether the president owns land.
- **Rationale:** the measure provides us with a general indicator of the president's wealth in the village.
- **Data source:** President survey

6. President male.

- **Procedure:** Coded 1 if president self-reports as male, 0 otherwise.
- **Coding:** measure with values 0 or 1 indicating whether the president is male.
- **Rationale:** the measure provides us with a general indicator of the president's gender privilege in the village.
- **Data source:** President survey

Informal capture.

Explicit measures:

1. **Citizen reports former president/other villager leads village events.** Village citizens' response to "Think about this village. At inaugural events or programs who tends to be the head? This might mean: who delivers the speech?"
 - **Procedure:** This was asked to citizens during the citizen survey
 - **Coding:** binary measure coded 1 when the interviewee named the former president or another villager (not current members of the body or family members), 0 otherwise.
 - **Rationale:** this measure provides us with an assessment of the other, non-elected villagers propensity to step in and represent the village in a village-wide meeting, as assessed by a local actor with knowledge of the gram panchayat's affairs.
 - **Data source:** Citizen survey
2. **Citizen nominated former president/other villager as village representative to bureaucrat.** Village citizens' response to Village citizens' response to "Suppose next month there will be a meeting with the Block Development Officer in which decisions about how to resolve your village's most urgent development problems will be made. You get to nominate one person to go and represent your village's interests in the meeting. This can be anyone. Of course, this is by law something that falls within the duties of the sarpanch. Who would you like to nominate? We're collecting nominations from villagers."
 - **Procedure:** This was asked to citizens during the citizen survey
 - **Coding:** binary measure coded 1 when the interviewee named the former president, former member, or another villager not in the GP (not current members of the body or family members), 0 otherwise.

- **Rationale:** this measure provides us with an assessment of the other, non-elected villagers propensity to step in and represent the village to the most important bureaucratic actor, as assessed by a local actor with knowledge of the gram panchayat's affairs.
 - **Data source:** Citizen survey
3. **President reports rich landowner influences council.** Presidents' response to "Is there a person in this village, like a village patil, who owns the majority of the land, is quite rich, and is important around here?" and "If yes, do they influence gram panchayat decisions and work?"
- **Procedure:** This was asked to presidents during the sarpanch survey
 - **Coding:** binary measure coded 1 when the interviewee reported that a rich landowner influences gram panchayat decisions and work, 0 otherwise.
 - **Rationale:** this measure provides us with an assessment of the other, non-elected villagers propensity to step in and influence village council affairs, as assessed by the president herself.
 - **Data source:** President survey

Implicit measures:

4. **Resignation filed: Administrative data.** Whether or not at least one president resignation was filed in a given village council. (Administrative census)
- **Procedure:** This was collected by the author by digitizing administrative resignation files.
 - **Coding:** binary measure coded 1 when the village council had documented at least one president resignation, 0 otherwise.
 - **Rationale:** this measure provides us with an assessment of the actual propensity of presidents to resign. Qualitative research suggests that resignations can indicate elite coordination in the background.
 - **Data source:** Administrative data
5. **Citizen reports resignation.** Citizens' response to the question: "In the current gram panchayat period, has there been more than one sarpanch or will there be more than one sarpanch (meaning has/will some sarpanch gave their resignation so another could be sarpanch, possibly to rotate the position)?"
- **Procedure:** This was asked to citizens during the sarpanch survey
 - **Coding:** binary measure coded 1 when the respondent said yes, 0 otherwise.
 - **Rationale:** this measure provides us with an assessment of the reported propensity of presidents to resign. Qualitative research suggests that resignations can indicate elite coordination in the background.
 - **Data source:** Citizen survey

6. **President reports resignation.** Presidents' response to the question: "Was/will your tenure shared/be shared with other members, or did/will you serve for the full tenure?"
- **Procedure:** This was asked to presidents during the sarpanch survey
 - **Coding:** binary measure coded 1 when the respondent said that they were multiple presidents during the tenure, 0 when the respondent said they would enjoy the full term.
 - **Rationale:** this measure provides us with an assessment of the self-reported propensity of presidents to resign. Qualitative research suggests that resignations can indicate elite coordination in the background.
 - **Data source:** President survey
7. **President elected unopposed.** Presidents' response to the question: "did you contest unopposed, or were there others who stood in the competition?"
- **Procedure:** This was asked to presidents during the sarpanch survey
 - **Coding:** binary measure coded 1 when the respondent said they contested unopposed, 0 when the respondent said there were others who stood in the competition.
 - **Rationale:** this measure provides us with an assessment of whether presidents faced any electoral competition in becoming elected. Qualitative research suggests that unopposed elections can indicate elite coordination in the background.
 - **Data source:** President survey

C Quasi-experimental electoral cycles: Further evidence

C.1 The history of political decentralization in Maharashtra

Maharashtra has a long history of village council elections, with some village governments established as early as 1869 (in what was then British-ruled Bombay Province). Prior to the reorganization of the Indian states in 1956 and the subsequent division of the Bombay state into contemporary Gujarat and Maharashtra, rural local bodies were governed largely at the whims of local elites. Sometimes elections were held regularly, and other times they were not. Village councils were also established at differing times (see next section) – with some established in the colonial era, and others forming ever since.

It was not until 1958, with the landmark *Bombay Village Panchayats Act*, that a unified law was put forth to govern all of the region’s local governments. This act sought to specify and standardize the functioning of village councils across the state elections - positing, for example, that village council elections take place every four years, and that each revenue village or group of revenue villages have its own village government. This marked the first attempt to standardize Maharashtra’s electoral cycles, fixing them at four years. Despite the passing of the landmark *Bombay Village Panchayats Act* in 1958, scholars note that its implementation was at times piecemeal.

The early 1990s brought the strongest attempt at standardization of village governments: with the passage of national legislation that sought to strengthen local governments across India. In particular, the state-appointed Patil Committee as well as the Bongirwar Committee compiled reports in the run-up to the 73rd constitutional amendment that highlighted the shortcomings of the current local government system in Maharashtra. The Patil Committee noted in 1986 the need for systematic elections to take place and be orchestrated by independent election machinery. Prior to this, the Bongirwar Committee noted the difficulty of the current election system - and particularly the fact that elections not only did not happen regularly across village councils, but also did not happen in a simultaneous fashion across the state. They recommended that “elections to [village councils]... should be held at a stretch and almost simultaneously,” but the state government did not accept this recommendation. Moreover, national reformers decided that all states should hold village council elections every five years, beginning from the time that their State Election Commissions would be set up and ready to conduct elections.

According to bureaucrats at the top of the hierarchy of the State Election Commission, state leaders decided to continue to hold asynchronous elections in 1995 for political reasons. Plus, they were able to do so because the 73rd Constitutional Amendment devolved the decisions around the specifics of election administration to states. In the early 1990s, Congress – the state’s historically dominant party – was facing an existential crisis of dwindling support and, particularly, a shrinking rural voter base. Crucially, Congress was implementing Maharashtra’s version of the 73rd amendment requirements in the context of upcoming 1995 State Assembly elections. State leaders feared that if they dissolved all rural bodies, they would lose crucial rural support in the lead-up to the Assembly elections. As a result, they agreed to hold elections every five years, but decided to do so asynchronously – maintaining the state’s impressively staggered election schedule. This is in contrast to the neighboring state of Karnataka, which decided to dissolve all rural bodies and hold synchronous village

council elections in the same period.³

In all, there were three distinct periods of electoral cycles in Maharashtra until contemporary times, but electoral cycles were initially determined with differing establishment dates. Pre-1958, elections were held sporadically, according to the whims of local leaders. Between 1958 and 1995, elections were held at 4-year intervals, though historical accounts suggest that this was not universally respected across the state. Finally, from 1995 onwards, elections were with more regularity at 5-year intervals. While establishment dates determined the initial “path” of a village council, other village-level idiosyncracies, exogenous events, and bureaucratic arbitrariness pushed some councils further off their paths.

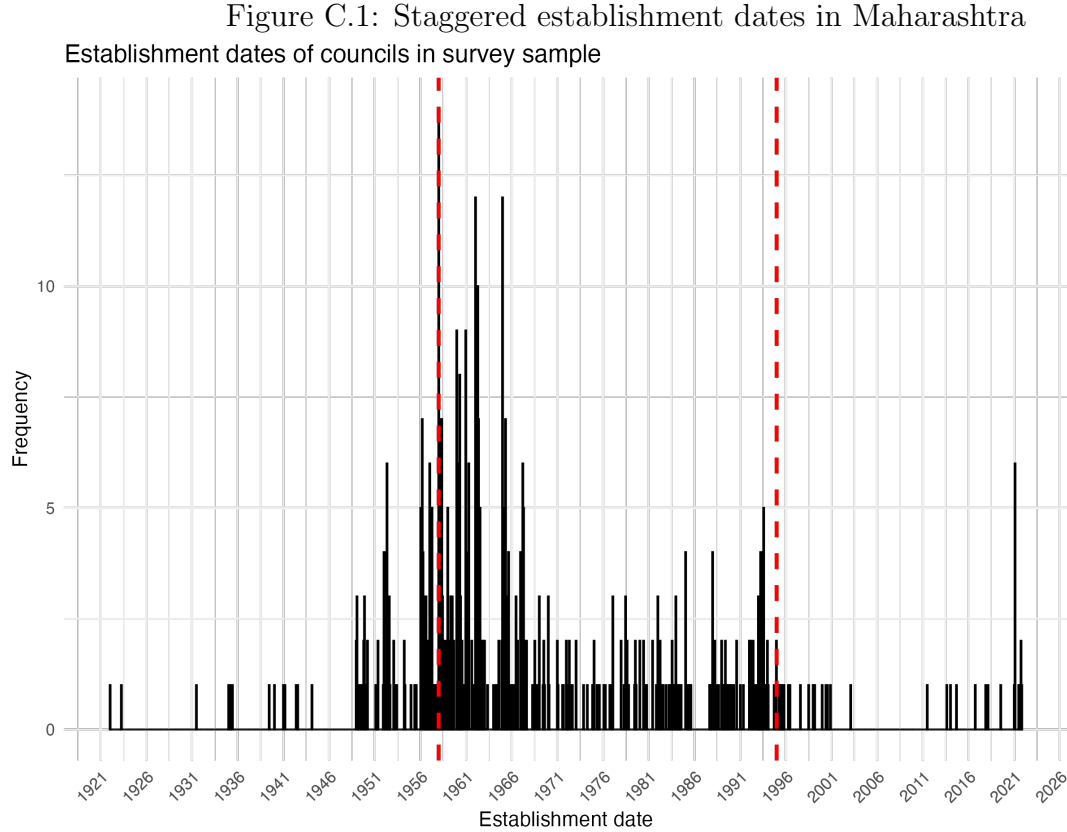
C.2 Analysis: Establishment dates and electoral cycles

As noted above, village councils in Maharashtra were established at varying times, and this set the foundation for varying electoral cycles. Figure C.1 below shows the distribution of establishment dates from the villages in the survey data used in this paper. The first red line is at 1958, with the first electoral cycle reform (elections every 4-years). The second red line is at 1995, with the second electoral cycle regime (elections every 5-years). Village councils were established before 1958, between 1958 and 1995, and after 1995.

Establishment years are predictive of the latest election cycle recorded in the survey data, suggesting that they play a key role in setting the foundation for today’s electoral cycles (shown in Table C.1.). However, the mapping is not one to one: establishment dates do not fully predict current electoral cycles, i.e. they are not deterministic. This provides additional evidence that due to additional exogenous events or bureaucratic reasons, some village councils deviated from their initial paths.

Moreover, and crucially, these variables are not imbalanced across villages who had elections between July and January 2020 – directly – and those who had their elections outside of this timeframe – indirectly. This is shown in Table C.2 below, which regresses three measures of establishment dates on an indicator for direct election in the electoral cycle studied in this paper. The measures are: whether the council was established pre-1958, whether the council was established between 1958 and 1995, and whether the council was established 1995 onwards. Taken together, these data provide further (albeit imperfect) quantitative indicators that explain why electoral cycles in Maharashtra are impressively staggered – due to differing establishment dates, differing electoral cycles regimes with differing levels of enforcement, as well as additional exogenous events and bureaucratic arbitrariness. Because indicators for establishment dates are, however, balanced across direct and indirect councils, this provides further support for a plausible quasi-experimental set-up.

³Interview by author in Jodhpur on 25 July 2024.



Note: This figure represents the distribution of establishment dates across the survey sample of village councils in Maharashtra. The x-axis represents years, spaced every 5 years. The y-axis represents the frequency of establishment years that took place in a given year.

C.3 Additional qualitative evidence

Additional interview evidence supports the idea that exogenous events and bureaucratic arbitrariness further pushed village councils off of their initial “paths.”

An official who works in the village council election office, stated: “...there were changes in different [village councils]... the dates for the [village councils] elections [move] around... And it’s been a long time since the system was established, during which all these changes gradually happened. Now, even if we were to reset all the dates of the [village councils] so that all the elections are on the same day, after some years, we would be in the same situation we are in now.”⁴ When I asked the head of one district why elections seemingly occurred all the time throughout the state, he responded: “It keeps happening every year. The 5-year tenure is getting over at different times... Elections are very local. It’s not that there’s one is a group [village council] and another is a single [village council]... Elections happen every year, every month...” Another district-level bureaucrat held the same view, stating: “Due to many arbitrary reasons, the dates [of village council elections] are not in sync.” He added that bureaucratic constraints may shift electoral cycles: “Dates are announced at different places. Sometimes it’s not possible to conduct the elections in so many places at the same

⁴Interviews by author in Jodhpur on 25 July 2024 and Pune district on 11, 16, and 17 July 2022.

Table C.1: Establishment date predicts electoral cycle

	(1)
(Intercept)	1982.765*** (10.278)
Establishment year	0.018*** (0.005)
Num.Obs.	576
R2	0.017
R2 Adj.	0.015

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Regression of council establishment year on the current electoral cycle year with robust standard errors.

Table C.2: Direct elections do not predict establishment

	Established pre-1958	Established between 1958 and 1995	Established post-1995
(Intercept)	0.214*** (0.022)	0.704*** (0.024)	0.082*** (0.015)
Direct election	-0.020 (0.034)	0.047 (0.038)	-0.027 (0.021)
Num.Obs.	576	576	576
R2	0.001	0.003	0.003
R2 Adj.	-0.001	0.001	0.001

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Regression of various outcomes on the whether the village council had a direct election, with robust standard errors.

time...” A third official who works in the village council election office itself, stated: “...there were changes in different [village councils]... the dates for the [village councils] elections [move] around... And it’s been a long time since the system was established, during which

all these changes gradually happened. Now, even if we were to reset all the dates of the [village councils] so that all the elections are on the same day, after some years, we would be in the same situation we are in now.”⁵

⁵Interviews by author in Jodhpur on 25 July 2024 and Pune district on 11, 16, and 17 July 2022.

C.4 Balance table: Variable description

The pre-treatment covariates in the balance table were constructed in the following manner. The first ten are directly taken from an administrative survey with the local village bureaucrat, the *gram sevak*, who reported administrative statistics about the village. The enumerators were assigned to verify the administrative information provided by the *gram sevak* by checking the documents provided by the *gram sevak* to validate the information. These questions directly appear in the *gram sevak* administrative survey and their values are directly reported, thus coder discretion in coding covariates is minimized. Quota status variables were collected via the interview with the council president and verified using paper administrative records in Marathi for each village council.

1. No. villages: The number of villages in the village council.
2. Population: The population of the village council.
3. Percent SC pop.: The proportion of the village council population comprising people from the SC category.
4. Distance to block (km): The distance from the village council office to the block office in kilometers. The reported distance to reach the block office.
5. Time to block (hr): The time from the village council office to the block office in hours. The reported number of hours it takes to reach the block office.
6. Speed to block (km/h): The speed from the village council office to the block office in kilometers per hour. The reported distance to the block office divided by the reported number of hours it takes to reach there.
7. Pilgrimage sites: 1 if there exist significant pilgrimage sites in the village council, 0 otherwise. This is directly coded from the *gram sevak*'s reports.
8. Historic sites: 1 if there exist significant historic sites in the village council, 0 otherwise. This is directly coded from the *gram sevak*'s reports.
9. Economic opportunities: 1 if there exist significant economic opportunities in the village council, 0 otherwise. This is directly coded from the *gram sevak*'s reports.
10. Electricity grid: 1 if all villages in the village council connected to the state-provided electricity grid, 0 otherwise. This is directly coded from the *gram sevak*'s reports.
11. Gender quota: 1 if the sarpanch seat is under a quota for women, 0 otherwise.
12. No caste quota: 1 if the sarpanch seat is under no caste quota, 0 otherwise.
13. OBC caste quota: 1 if the sarpanch seat is under a quota for OBCs, 0 otherwise.
14. SC caste quota: 1 if the sarpanch seat is under a quota for SCs, 0 otherwise.

C.5 Tests for joint significance

This appendix presents a regression that tests for the joint significance of covariates in predicting treatment assignment (whether a village council had direct versus indirect elections). The p-value of the F-statistic is large. In other words, I do not find evidence for joint significance in covariates in predicting treatment assignment. This provides additional evidence for the quasi-experimental set-up.

Table C.3: Joint prediction of direct election

	(1)
No. villages	0.037 (0.030)
Population	0.000 (0.000)
Percent SC pop.	-0.049 (0.177)
Distance to block (km)	-0.001 (0.002)
Time to block (hr)	0.019* (0.007)
Speed to block (km/hr)	0.000 (0.000)
Pilgrimage sites	0.001 (0.046)
Historic sites	-0.020 (0.064)
Economic opportunities	-0.022 (0.048)
Electricity grid	0.034 (0.110)
Gender quota	-0.057 (0.040)
OBC caste quota	0.059 (0.050)
SC caste quota	-0.003 (0.049)
Num.Obs.	594
R2	0.013
R2 Adj.	-0.009
F.statistic	1.03
F.p.value	0.421

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Regression of a binary indicator for direct election on covariates with robust standard errors. Open caste variable left out as reference category.

C.6 Assessing prognosis

In order to use the statistical tests shown in this appendix to bolster qualitative evidence for the statement that $\{Y_i(1), Y_i(0)\} \perp\!\!\!\perp Z_i$, their prognosis for potential outcomes is important. Though theoretical motivation is key, empirical assessment is also possible. In this appendix, I assess joint prognosis of covariates for the paper’s main *de facto* authority outcomes. Below, I present regressions of covariates on potential outcomes under control (observed potential outcomes among only those village councils that have indirect president elections). The prognosis R^2 are sizeable, and the p-value of the F-statistics are very small in all regressions. For instance, Bicalho, Bouyamourn, and Dunning (2025) note a threshold for a prognosis R^2 of around 0.1 as ”meaningfully prognostic.”⁶ This diagnostic suggests that together, these covariates predict reasonably well potential outcomes. This should give us confidence in the statistical tests conducted previously in order to probe the unconfoundedness assumptions undergirding the quasi-experiment.

⁶Bicalho, Clara, Bouyamourn, Adam, and Thad Dunning. 2025. “The Power of Prognosis: Improving Covariate Balance Tests with Outcome Information.” Working paper, Department of Political Science, University of California, Berkeley.

Table C.4: Joint prognosis of covariates

	President self-perception as main decision-maker in monthly meeting	President perceived as most influential actor in discussion	Proportion of time president spoke in discussion	Citizen nominated president as village representative to bureaucrat	Citizen reports president leads village events
No. villages	0.062 (0.038)	0.017 (0.037)	0.005 (0.010)	0.013 (0.020)	−0.024 (0.020)
Population	−0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	−0.000** (0.000)	−0.000 (0.000)
Percent SC pop.	−0.107 (0.171)	0.163 (0.167)	0.156* (0.067)	0.229* (0.112)	0.344** (0.118)
Distance to block (km)	0.002 (0.002)	−0.001 (0.002)	−0.002* (0.001)	0.000 (0.002)	−0.000 (0.001)
Time to block (hr)	−0.019 (0.029)	0.012 (0.042)	0.001 (0.012)	0.013 (0.028)	−0.006 (0.025)
Speed to block (km/hr)	−0.000 (0.000)	0.000** (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	−0.000 (0.000)	−0.000 (0.000)
Pilgrimage sites	−0.004 (0.048)	0.004 (0.044)	−0.007 (0.016)	0.038 (0.029)	0.055+ (0.032)
Historic sites	−0.086 (0.058)	−0.034 (0.059)	−0.048* (0.024)	−0.026 (0.047)	−0.085+ (0.043)
Economic opportunities	0.006 (0.050)	0.016 (0.046)	0.009 (0.017)	0.069* (0.031)	−0.003 (0.034)
Electricity grid	0.260*** (0.043)	0.200*** (0.041)	0.047 (0.030)	−0.035 (0.063)	−0.055 (0.069)
Gender quota	−0.168*** (0.043)	−0.225*** (0.040)	−0.119*** (0.014)	−0.118*** (0.027)	−0.050+ (0.028)
OBC caste quota	−0.110* (0.053)	−0.029 (0.052)	−0.002 (0.019)	−0.011 (0.034)	−0.017 (0.033)
SC caste quota	−0.093+ (0.053)	−0.089+ (0.045)	−0.021 (0.016)	−0.072* (0.033)	−0.043 (0.034)
Num.Obs.	354	363	362	2164	2133
R2	0.082	0.124	0.211	0.031	0.017
F.statistic	4.033	28.024	9.101	4.687	1.858
F.p.value	0	0	0	0	0.034

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each main outcome on covariates, among the control group (indirectly elected councils). All regressions use robust standard errors. Citizen survey outcomes cluster SEs at the village council level.

C.7 Prognostic-weighted balance tests

I use Bicalho, Bouyamoun and Dunning (2025)’s prognostic-weighted covariate balance tests as an additional diagnostic to probe assumptions underlying as-if random. Their method produces a single informativeness-weighted test statistic that prioritizes the covariates measured

that are the most associated with potential outcomes. Bicalho, Bouyamourn and Dunning (2025:3) develop a test statistic that “is a weighted sum of standardized mean differences for individual covariates, where the weights are measures of prognosis.” Bootstrap hypothesis tests then produce p-values for the prognosis-weighted test statistics. Table C.5 below displays the p-value of each prognostic-weighted test for each main outcome used in this paper, produced using Bicalho, Bouyamourn, and Dunning (2025)’s package `pwtest`. None of the p -values fall under conventional thresholds of statistical significance, as they range from 0.17 to 0.78 (displayed in Table C.5). These diagnostics provide additional evidence consistent with as-if random.

Table C.5: Prognostic-weighted covariate balance tests

Outcome	Prognostic-weighted test statistic	Bootstrapped p-value
President perceived as most influential actor in discussion	0.040	0.250
Proportion of time president spoke in discussion	0.048	0.278
President self-perception as main decision-maker in monthly meeting	0.027	0.370
Citizen nominated president as village representative to bureaucrat	0.009	0.174
Citizen reports president leads village events	0.001	0.788

Note: Each row represents a prognostic-weighted covariate test for each main outcome. Covariates used are those presented in the balance table in the main paper.

C.8 Partisan targeting

While – as discussed in the main paper – the direct election reform likely had political motivations on a macro-scale, evidence does not support that its implementation in specific village councils was targeted in a partisan manner at the micro-level.

The reform was implemented at the village-level as soon as it was passed at the state-level, in the monsoon session of the state legislature in 2017. Election bureaucrats confirm that it is not the case, for example, that an implementation lag occurred wherein certain village councils were able to hold their elections indirectly after the passage of the law. As soon as the Maha Vikas Aghadi coalition (an alliance between the Shiva Sena, National Congress Party, and Indian National Congress) came to power at the end of 2019, they moved to reinstate indirect elections, which was passed and implemented promptly in January 2020. Even though this is not the reform period under study, as soon as the BJP-led coalition came into power again in June 2022, they passed and implemented a reform to move back to direct elections by the end of that summer. These behaviors and their timing suggest that each party had developed a clear preference around which village council elections it preferred, and moved to realize these preferences as early as possible within their time in office, rather than, for instance, strategically timing the passage of the electoral reforms so that certain councils would receive certain electoral regimes.

Indeed, a preference of the BJP over the type of electoral system does not imply that it could allocate the system to particular villages, in a way that would violate as-if random. Interviews with BJP party leaders suggests that the party did not have discretion over where the reform was implemented when it was passed in 2017. Engaging in partisan “targeting” in this manner would require tracking the state’s impressively staggered elections, matching election timings to places where the BJP lacked a strong base, and intentionally timing the passage of the reform such that it would be implemented in only these places (or, alternatively, selectively implementing the reform in these places). Interviewees report a general inability to interfere in the Election Commission’s independent election implementation process as well as the lack of incentive to do so: perceived election manipulation would not bode well for electoral support, they explained. Plus, they averred the BJP’s incentive was not to target the reform only to certain places, but rather to implement it broadly across the state as it had become a part of the party’s brand in promoting efficiency and development. In addition, the lack of an ability to target and the lack of incentive to do so are compounded by the fact that direct and indirect villages in the survey sample do not exhibit differential citizen preferences for the BJP (post-treatment), which I show in Appendix D.3. Appendix D.3 demonstrates similar political party support across both direct and indirect villages, as well as statistically indistinguishable citizen support for the BJP and Congress across direct and indirect villages. This analysis of citizen partisan support are post-treatment and thus require caveating. To the extent that partisan identities are sticky, one may expect that if the BJP successfully targeted direct elections’ implementation in places with differential party support, this would be detectable after the reform as well.

D Results and robustness: Quasi-experimental observational design

D.1 Main results

D.1.1 Regression results from Figure 4

This appendix presents the full regression tables that underlie the numbers reported in Figure 4 in the main paper.

Table D.1: The impact of direct election on de facto authority

	President self-perception as main decision-maker in monthly meeting	President perceived as most influential actor in discussion	Proportion of time president spoke in discussion	Citizen nominated president as village representative to bureaucrat	Citizen reports president leads village events
(Intercept)	0.211*** (0.021)	0.178*** (0.020)	0.259*** (0.008)	0.583*** (0.014)	0.617*** (0.014)
Direct election	0.114** (0.037)	0.151*** (0.037)	0.052*** (0.013)	0.082*** (0.021)	0.132*** (0.021)
Num.Obs.	595	604	603	3603	3536
R2	0.016	0.030	0.026	0.007	0.019

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each main outcome on direct election. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

D.1.2 Robustness 1: Timing

This appendix presents the regressions from Figure 4 in the main paper, each subsetting into two regressions: one examining the impact of direct election in the first transition to direct elections (left column), and the other estimating the impact of direct election among the villages in the second transition (back to indirect elections).

Table D.2: The impact of direct election on de facto authority, by transition

	Impact of direct: first transition	Impact of direct: second transition
President self-perception as main decision-maker in monthly meeting		
(Intercept)	0.159*** (0.030)	0.248*** (0.030)
Direct election	0.166*** (0.043)	0.077+ (0.043)
Num.Obs.	385	444
R2	0.034	0.007
President perceived as most influential actor in discussion		
(Intercept)	0.182*** (0.031)	0.175*** (0.026)
Direct election	0.147*** (0.043)	0.154*** (0.040)
Num.Obs.	393	445
R2	0.026	0.031
Proportion of time president spoke in discussion		
(Intercept)	0.258*** (0.013)	0.259*** (0.010)
Direct election	0.053** (0.017)	0.051*** (0.015)
Num.Obs.	392	445
R2	0.025	0.026
Citizen nominated president as village representative to bureaucrat		
(Intercept)	0.571*** (0.020)	0.592*** (0.018)
Direct election	0.094*** (0.026)	0.072** (0.024)
Num.Obs.	2350	2648
R2	0.009	0.006
Citizen reports president leads village events		
(Intercept)	0.648*** (0.019)	0.593*** (0.019)
Direct election	0.100*** (0.025)	0.156*** (0.024)
Num.Obs.	2296	2603
R2	0.012	0.027

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each main outcome on direct election. The left column does so for the first transition, and the right column for the second transition. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

D.1.3 Robustness 2: Quotas

This appendix analyses the outcomes from Figure 4 in the main paper in the context of quotas in two ways. Table D.3. does so by estimating the same regressions that underlie Figure 4 in the main paper among three subsets of the village councils from the sample: those with the president seat reserved for women (left column), those with the president seat reserved for OBCs/open (middle column), those with the president seat reserved for SCs (right column). Table D.4 compares the impact of direct election for each outcome to the impact of gender quotas and SC quotas.

Table D.3: The impact of direct election on de facto authority, by quotas

	Gender-reserved seats	OBC/Open seats	SC-reserved seats
President self-perception as main decision-maker in monthly meeting			
(Intercept)	0.133*** (0.025)	0.218*** (0.027)	0.195*** (0.037)
Direct election	0.187*** (0.052)	0.107* (0.046)	0.134* (0.066)
Num.Obs.	286	403	191
R2	0.051	0.014	0.023
President perceived as most influential actor in discussion			
(Intercept)	0.070*** (0.019)	0.201*** (0.025)	0.132*** (0.031)
Direct election	0.090* (0.040)	0.149** (0.046)	0.155* (0.062)
Num.Obs.	292	409	194
R2	0.021	0.028	0.037
Proportion of time president spoke in discussion			
(Intercept)	0.202*** (0.009)	0.265*** (0.010)	0.245*** (0.011)
Direct election	0.031+ (0.017)	0.065*** (0.017)	0.023 (0.020)
Num.Obs.	291	408	194
R2	0.013	0.035	0.007
Citizen nominated president as village representative to bureaucrat			
(Intercept)	0.531*** (0.019)	0.605*** (0.017)	0.537*** (0.024)
Direct election	0.078* (0.032)	0.088*** (0.025)	0.071+ (0.040)
Num.Obs.	1725	2437	1160
R2	0.006	0.008	0.005
Citizen reports president leads village events			
(Intercept)	0.593*** (0.019)	0.629*** (0.016)	0.592*** (0.025)
Direct election	0.096** (0.031)	0.141*** (0.024)	0.108** (0.039)
Num.Obs.	1702	2389	1141
R2	0.009	0.022	0.012

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each main outcome on direct election. The left column does so among gender-reserved seats, the middle column for OBC/Open seats, and the right column for SC-reserved seats. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

Table D.4: Benchmarking the impact of direct election on de facto authority

	Impact of direct	Impact of gender quota	Impact of SC quota
President self-perception as main decision-maker in monthly meeting			
(Intercept)	0.211*** (0.021)	0.304*** (0.026)	0.260*** (0.022)
Direct election	0.114** (0.037)		
Gender quota		-0.101** (0.035)	
SC quota			-0.014 (0.038)
Num.Obs.	595	595	595
R2	0.016	0.013	0.000
President perceived as most influential actor in discussion			
(Intercept)	0.178*** (0.020)	0.362*** (0.027)	0.259*** (0.022)
Direct election	0.151*** (0.037)		
Gender quota		-0.259*** (0.033)	
SC quota			-0.068+ (0.036)
Num.Obs.	604	604	604
R2	0.030	0.093	0.006
Proportion of time president spoke in discussion			
(Intercept)	0.259*** (0.008)	0.340*** (0.009)	0.291*** (0.008)
Direct election	0.052*** (0.013)		
Gender quota		-0.126*** (0.012)	
SC quota			-0.037** (0.013)
Num.Obs.	603	603	603
R2	0.026	0.159	0.012
Citizen nominated president as village representative to bureaucrat			
(Intercept)	0.583*** (0.014)	0.665*** (0.014)	0.639*** (0.012)
Direct election	0.082*** (0.021)		
Gender quota		-0.106*** (0.021)	
SC quota			-0.075** (0.023)
Num.Obs.	3603	3603	3603
R2	0.007	0.012	0.005
Citizen reports president leads village events			
(Intercept)	0.617*** (0.014)	0.704*** (0.014)	0.684*** (0.013)
Direct election	0.132*** (0.021)		
Gender quota		-0.077*** (0.021)	
SC quota			-0.051* (0.023)
Num.Obs.	3536	3536	3536
R2	0.019	0.007	0.003

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each main outcome on either direct election, gender quota, or SC quota. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

D.1.4 Robustness 3: Controlling for observables

This appendix presents the same regressions from Appendices D.1.1 and D.1.2., this time adding controls (covariates from Figure 3) to the regressions.

Table D.5: The impact of direct election on de facto authority, controlling for observables

	President self-perception as main decision-maker in monthly meeting	President perceived as most influential actor in discussion	Proportion of time president spoke in discussion	Citizen nominated president as village representative to bureaucrat	Citizen reports president leads village events
(Intercept)	0.014 (0.061)	0.243* (0.100)	0.316*** (0.037)	0.654*** (0.054)	0.693*** (0.057)
Direct election	0.108** (0.038)	0.131*** (0.035)	0.042*** (0.012)	0.076*** (0.021)	0.136*** (0.020)
No. villages	0.015 (0.028)	0.039 (0.026)	−0.000 (0.008)	0.003 (0.014)	−0.043** (0.016)
Population	0.000 (0.000)	0.000* (0.000)	0.000* (0.000)	−0.000 (0.000)	−0.000 (0.000)
Percent SC pop.	−0.112 (0.138)	0.263+ (0.135)	0.178*** (0.051)	0.166* (0.077)	0.306*** (0.082)
Distance to block (km)	0.002 (0.002)	−0.000 (0.002)	−0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)
Time to block (hr)	−0.007+ (0.004)	0.004 (0.018)	0.002 (0.002)	−0.008 (0.006)	−0.009 (0.008)
Speed to block (km/hr)	−0.000* (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	−0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	−0.000 (0.000)
Pilgrimage sites	0.022 (0.040)	−0.003 (0.036)	0.001 (0.013)	0.017 (0.023)	0.032 (0.022)
Historic sites	−0.082 (0.053)	−0.029 (0.050)	−0.023 (0.020)	−0.005 (0.036)	−0.025 (0.031)
Economic opportunities	0.036 (0.042)	−0.001 (0.038)	0.013 (0.013)	0.020 (0.023)	−0.000 (0.024)
Electricity grid	0.288*** (0.028)	0.006 (0.085)	0.002 (0.031)	−0.045 (0.046)	−0.031 (0.047)
Gender quota	−0.099** (0.036)	−0.251*** (0.033)	−0.126*** (0.012)	−0.107*** (0.021)	−0.073*** (0.020)
OBC caste quota	−0.119** (0.043)	−0.057 (0.041)	−0.008 (0.015)	−0.001 (0.025)	−0.005 (0.023)
SC caste quota	−0.091* (0.044)	−0.098* (0.040)	−0.041** (0.013)	−0.074** (0.026)	−0.048+ (0.025)
Num.Obs.	585	594	593	3544	3481
R2	0.066	0.152	0.222	0.029	0.040

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each main outcome on direct election and the covariates from Figure 3. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

Table D.6: The impact of direct election on de facto authority, by transition (with controls)

	President self-perception as main decision-maker in monthly meeting			President perceived as most influential actor in discussion			Proportion of time president spoke in discussion			Citizen nominated president as village representative to bureau/central			Citizen reports president leads village events		
	Impact of direct: first transition	Impact of direct: second transition	Impact of direct: first transition	Impact of direct: second transition	Impact of direct: first transition	Impact of direct: second transition	Impact of direct: first transition	Impact of direct: second transition	Impact of direct: first transition	Impact of direct: second transition	Impact of direct: first transition	Impact of direct: second transition	Impact of direct: first transition	Impact of direct: second transition	Impact of direct: second transition
(Intercept)	-0.007 (0.084)	0.032 (0.070)	0.403** (0.140)	0.273* (0.122)	0.329*** (0.062)	0.388*** (0.046)	0.677*** (0.062)	0.656*** (0.065)	0.781*** (0.056)	0.672*** (0.063)	0.781*** (0.056)	0.672*** (0.063)	0.781*** (0.056)	0.672*** (0.063)	0.672*** (0.063)
Direct election	0.168*** (0.045)	0.070 (0.044)	0.121** (0.043)	0.135*** (0.039)	0.042** (0.016)	0.042** (0.016)	0.022** (0.026)	0.002** (0.024)	0.107*** (0.024)	0.002** (0.024)	0.107*** (0.024)	0.002** (0.024)	0.107*** (0.024)	0.002** (0.024)	0.135*** (0.024)
No. villages	-0.012 (0.036)	0.004 (0.030)	0.034 (0.033)	0.053+ (0.030)	-0.005 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.021 (0.017)	0.010 (0.014)	-0.050** (0.020)	0.010 (0.014)	-0.050** (0.020)	0.010 (0.014)	-0.050** (0.020)	0.010 (0.017)	-0.049** (0.017)
Population	0.060* (0.000)	0.000** (0.000)	0.000** (0.000)	0.000* (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
Percent SC pop.	-0.172 (0.188)	-0.126 (0.161)	0.164 (0.179)	0.285** (0.158)	0.133* (0.066)	0.230*** (0.059)	0.065 (0.095)	0.211* (0.080)	0.225* (0.090)	0.065 (0.095)	0.225* (0.090)	0.065 (0.090)	0.225* (0.090)	0.065 (0.100)	0.364*** (0.100)
Distance to block (km)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	-0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)	0.002 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	0.002* (0.001)	0.002 (0.001)	0.002* (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	0.002* (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.001)
Time to block (hr)	-0.007 (0.006)	-0.008* (0.004)	0.005 (0.026)	0.004 (0.017)	0.002 (0.001)	0.002 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.007)	-0.011 (0.003)	-0.008 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.003)	-0.008 (0.000)	-0.010 (0.000)	-0.008 (0.000)	-0.010 (0.000)	-0.010 (0.000)
Speed to block (km/hr)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000*** (0.000)	0.000** (0.006)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.000+ (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
Pilgrimage sites	0.017 (0.051)	0.026 (0.048)	0.006 (0.048)	-0.014 (0.042)	0.003 (0.017)	0.007 (0.015)	0.007 (0.028)	0.009 (0.025)	-0.002 (0.025)	0.009 (0.025)	-0.002 (0.025)	0.009 (0.025)	-0.002 (0.025)	0.009 (0.025)	0.009 (0.025)
Historic sites	-0.108 (0.060)	-0.046 (0.069)	-0.008 (0.064)	-0.033 (0.062)	-0.005 (0.026)	-0.015 (0.022)	0.004 (0.048)	0.013 (0.039)	0.026 (0.038)	0.013 (0.039)	0.026 (0.038)	0.013 (0.039)	0.026 (0.038)	0.013 (0.038)	-0.016 (0.032)
Economic opportunities	0.054 (0.052)	0.051 (0.053)	-0.048 (0.050)	0.019 (0.048)	0.020 (0.026)	0.009 (0.015)	0.017 (0.029)	-0.005 (0.027)	0.000 (0.028)	-0.005 (0.027)	0.000 (0.028)	-0.005 (0.027)	0.000 (0.028)	-0.007 (0.028)	-0.007 (0.028)
Electricity grid	0.274*** (0.042)	0.323*** (0.032)	-0.138 (0.122)	-0.056 (0.166)	-0.022 (0.043)	-0.022 (0.038)	-0.051 (0.050)	-0.043 (0.055)	-0.078+ (0.043)	-0.043 (0.055)	-0.078+ (0.043)	-0.043 (0.055)	-0.078+ (0.043)	0.025 (0.048)	0.025 (0.048)
Gender quota	-0.063 (0.042)	-0.078+ (0.044)	-0.253*** (0.043)	-0.271*** (0.030)	-0.127*** (0.016)	-0.132*** (0.013)	-0.114*** (0.026)	-0.098*** (0.021)	-0.087*** (0.024)	-0.098*** (0.021)	-0.087*** (0.024)	-0.098*** (0.021)	-0.087*** (0.024)	-0.087*** (0.024)	-0.087*** (0.024)
ODC caste quota	-0.135** (0.052)	-0.115* (0.054)	-0.093+ (0.051)	-0.052 (0.040)	-0.014 (0.019)	-0.010 (0.017)	-0.018 (0.020)	0.021 (0.028)	-0.038 (0.027)	0.021 (0.028)	-0.038 (0.027)	0.021 (0.028)	-0.038 (0.027)	0.032 (0.027)	0.032 (0.027)
SC caste quota	-0.081 (0.057)	-0.109* (0.054)	-0.104+ (0.054)	-0.103* (0.048)	-0.036** (0.018)	-0.043** (0.015)	-0.047 (0.032)	-0.090** (0.030)	-0.073* (0.030)	-0.090** (0.030)	-0.073* (0.030)	-0.090** (0.030)	-0.073* (0.030)	-0.073* (0.030)	-0.073* (0.030)
Num.Obs.	377	439	385	440	384	440	2303	2621	2252	2303	2252	2621	2252	2303	2377
R2	0.086	0.055	0.150	0.178	0.211	0.257	0.031	0.032	0.042	0.031	0.042	0.032	0.042	0.031	0.056

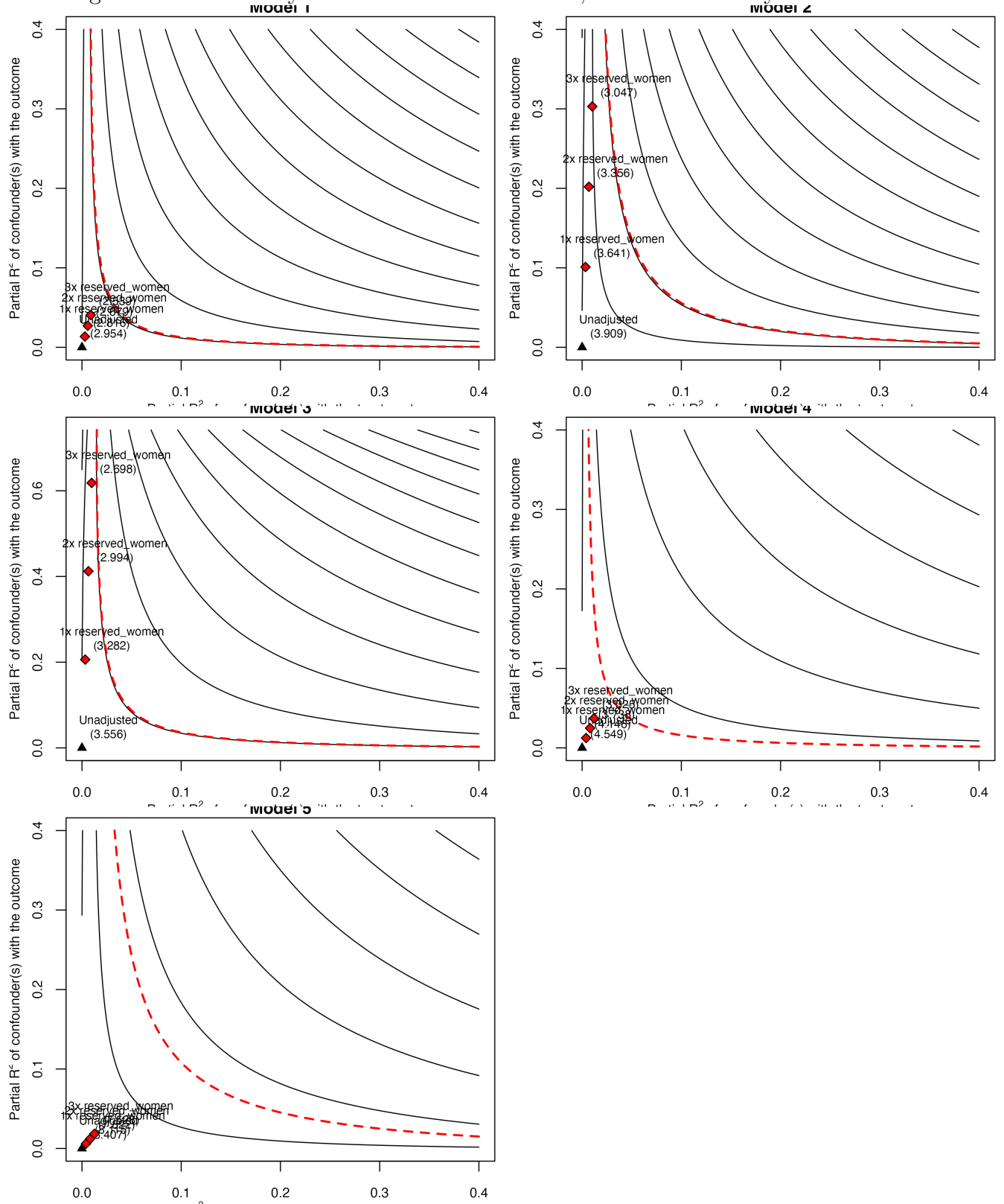
+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each main outcome on direct election and controls. For each outcome, the left column does so for the first transition, and the right column for the second transition. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

D.1.5 Robustness 4: Probing the role of unobservables through sensitivity analysis

I use the `sensemakr` package in R, developed by Cinelli and Hazlett (2020) to probe the role unobservables could play in confounding effects. Figure D.1 below plots the sensitivity of the t -values associated with the estimates of main effects (for the five *de facto* authority outcomes, using linear regressions), using the gender quota variable as a benchmark to understand how strong unobservables would have to be to significantly change the interpretation of this paper’s results. In the plots below, the red line indicates a t -value of 2, the conventional approximate value for 95 % confidence intervals. Each of the red dots plots hypothetical unobserved confounders as strong as, twice as strong as, and three times as strong as the gender quota variable. For each of the authority outcomes, the plots demonstrate that unobserved confounders would have to have more than three times the strength of the gender quota variable for the results of this paper to become statistically insignificant. This seems implausible, as gender quotas are extremely theoretically and empirically important in this context in terms of explaining authority outcomes.

Figure D.1: Sensitivity of t -value to unobservables, de facto authority outcomes



Note: Each figure plots the sensitivity of the t -value of each coefficient estimate of each authority outcome to unobserved confounders, using gender quotas as a benchmark.

D.1.6 Robustness 5: Additional qualitative evidence

This appendix documents additional qualitative evidence from the first round of theory-testing fieldwork that complements the empirical analyses in the main paper.

These findings map well onto evidence from interview data. First, interview evidence shows that village council presidents elected directly do indeed enjoy a “feeling” of *de facto* authority, and they often ascribe this feeling to the way they were elected. One president noted the importance of the sheer scale of direct elections, stating, “...I have been [directly] elected from among 1000 people. The fact that I have been elected by thousands of people, and not 15 members sitting at a temple gives me tremendous social power and authority.” Another president expressed pride in being selected by the people among 6 candidates: “I was contesting the elections with six other candidates... [and] the people chose me.” A third president smiled as she recounted her success during the election period, showing me a photo of her supporters hoisting her up into the air after the hotly contested direct election: “Out of all the [presidents] elected from among the people in the entire [administrative block], I was the one who got the largest number of votes.” She noticed the change in herself thanks to the authority she accrued via her election: “4 years ago, I would not have been able to speak so confidently even in front of you.” She continued, “...it’s better to be a [president] elected from among the people... if a [president] is elected from among the people, he gets a different kind of power from a [president] who is elected from among the members!”⁷

Indirectly elected council presidents recognize these authority differentials, wishing they would have enjoyed direct election. One president lamented feeling under pressure by elites, stating that, conversely, “Nobody can really put pressure on a [president] elected from among the people.” She felt disempowered by elite pressures: “They put a lot of pressure on me, but I kept going without giving in, which is when 90 percent of the villagers stopped speaking with me... They wouldn’t invite me to weddings, they wouldn’t call me, if I went to a wedding, they would insult me.” Another president stated frankly that “[Being elected] from among the people would be better, because that would mean [the president] has everyone’s support. From among the people is ideal. If he is elected from among the members, it’s a lot more political.” A third president was unequivocal in his opinion: “It’s better to be elected from among the people.” When asked why he felt that way, he responded: “If you get elected from among the people, you get a chance to actually get some work done properly.”⁸

⁷Interviews by author on 25 June and 3-10 July 2022.

⁸Interviews by author on 25 June and 3-9 July 2022.

D.2 Pathways

D.2.1 Regression results from Figure 5

This appendix presents the full regression tables that underlie the numbers reported in Figure 5 in the main paper.

Table D.7: The impact of direct election on formal elite capture

	Formal capture measures					
	President Maratha	Proportion land held by president's caste in village	President owns pacca house	President owns three/four-wheeler	President landed	President male
(Intercept)	0.232*** (0.022)	0.289*** (0.018)	0.511*** (0.026)	0.168*** (0.019)	0.334*** (0.025)	0.357*** (0.025)
Direct election	0.098** (0.038)	0.154*** (0.031)	0.105* (0.041)	0.119*** (0.035)	0.155*** (0.041)	0.160*** (0.041)
Num.Obs.	603	382	604	604	596	604
R2	0.012	0.065	0.010	0.020	0.024	0.025

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each formal capture outcome on direct election. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

Table D.8: The impact of direct election on informal elite capture

	Informal capture measures						
	Citizen reports former president/other villager leads village events	Citizen nominated former president/other villager as village representative to bureaucrat	President reports rich landowner influences council	Resignation filed: Administrative data	Citizen reports resignation	President reports resignation	President elected unopposed
(Intercept)	0.205*** (0.011)	0.168*** (0.009)	0.131*** (0.018)	0.193*** (0.014)	0.210*** (0.018)	0.233*** (0.022)	0.409*** (0.026)
Direct election	-0.057*** (0.015)	-0.052*** (0.014)	-0.083*** (0.023)	-0.138*** (0.017)	-0.180*** (0.020)	-0.207*** (0.024)	-0.281*** (0.034)
Num.Obs.	3536	3603	588	1366	3578	601	603
R2	0.005	0.005	0.018	0.039	0.064	0.078	0.089

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each informal capture outcome on direct election. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

D.2.2 Robustness 1: Timing

This appendix presents the regressions from Figure 5 in the main paper, each subsetting into four regressions: two examining the impact of direct election in the first transition to direct elections (left columns - one without and one with controls), and the other two estimating the impact of direct election among the villages in the second transition (back to indirect elections) (right columns - one without and one with controls).

Table D.9: The impact of direct election on formal elite capture, by transition

	Impact of direct: first transition (no controls)	Impact of direct: first transition (controls)	Impact of direct: second transition (no controls)	Impact of direct: second transition (controls)
President Maratha				
(Intercept)	0.289*** (0.036)	0.593*** (0.135)	0.190*** (0.027)	0.647*** (0.125)
Direct election	0.041 (0.047)	0.084+ (0.043)	0.141*** (0.041)	0.123*** (0.036)
Num.Obs.	392	384	444	439
R2	0.002	0.273	0.026	0.274
Proportion land held by president's caste in village				
(Intercept)	0.294* (0.123)	0.610*** (0.151)	0.289*** (0.019)	0.531*** (0.079)
Direct election	0.149 (0.126)	0.186+ (0.106)	0.154*** (0.031)	0.142*** (0.025)
Num.Obs.	173	172	376	375
R2	0.007	0.376	0.065	0.408
President owns pacca house				
(Intercept)	0.484*** (0.040)	0.612*** (0.161)	0.531*** (0.034)	0.605*** (0.149)
Direct election	0.131* (0.051)	0.148** (0.051)	0.085+ (0.047)	0.073 (0.047)
Num.Obs.	393	385	445	440
R2	0.017	0.081	0.007	0.069
President owns three/four wheeler				
(Intercept)	0.138*** (0.027)	0.065 (0.127)	0.190*** (0.027)	0.025 (0.089)
Direct election	0.148*** (0.040)	0.170*** (0.042)	0.097* (0.040)	0.094* (0.041)
Num.Obs.	393	385	445	440
R2	0.030	0.078	0.013	0.068
President landed				
(Intercept)	0.323*** (0.038)	0.382* (0.176)	0.343*** (0.033)	0.398* (0.157)
Direct election	0.167*** (0.050)	0.157*** (0.047)	0.146** (0.047)	0.110* (0.045)
Num.Obs.	386	379	441	436
R2	0.027	0.203	0.022	0.167
President male				
(Intercept)	0.314*** (0.037)	0.730*** (0.093)	0.389*** (0.034)	0.931*** (0.039)
Direct election	0.203*** (0.049)	0.156*** (0.031)	0.128** (0.047)	0.077** (0.023)
Num.Obs.	393	385	445	440
R2	0.040	0.741	0.017	0.790

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each formal capture outcome on direct election. The left column does so for the first transition, and the right column for the second transition. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

Table D.10: The impact of direct election on informal elite capture, by transition

	Impact of direct: first transition (no controls)	Impact of direct: first transition (controls)	Impact of direct: second transition (no controls)	Impact of direct: second transition (controls)
Citizen reports former president/other villager leads village events				
(Intercept)	0.204*** (0.013)	0.181*** (0.041)	0.206*** (0.014)	0.211*** (0.040)
Direct election	-0.056*** (0.016)	-0.057** (0.020)	-0.058** (0.018)	-0.060*** (0.018)
Num.Obs.	2296	2252	2603	2577
R2	0.005	0.016	0.006	0.017
Citizen nominated former president/other villager as village representative to bureaucrat				
(Intercept)	0.192*** (0.015)	0.148* (0.053)	0.149*** (0.012)	0.104* (0.047)
Direct election	-0.076*** (0.018)	-0.078*** (0.019)	-0.034* (0.015)	-0.028+ (0.016)
Num.Obs.	2350	2303	2648	2621
R2	0.011	0.020	0.002	0.009
President reports rich landowner influences council				
(Intercept)	0.168*** (0.031)	-0.035 (0.060)	0.105*** (0.021)	0.006 (0.072)
Direct election	-0.120*** (0.034)	-0.125*** (0.034)	-0.057* (0.025)	-0.048+ (0.026)
Num.Obs.	378	371	439	434
R2	0.040	0.079	0.012	0.055
Citizen reports resignation				
(Intercept)	0.390*** (0.033)	0.313*** (0.075)	0.069*** (0.012)	0.130* (0.060)
Direct election	-0.360*** (0.034)	-0.345*** (0.033)	-0.039** (0.015)	-0.040** (0.015)
Num.Obs.	2352	2309	2625	2598
R2	0.216	0.268	0.008	0.027
President reports resignation				
(Intercept)	0.418*** (0.039)	0.387*** (0.108)	0.095*** (0.020)	0.049 (0.033)
Direct election	-0.392*** (0.041)	-0.379*** (0.040)	-0.069** (0.023)	-0.069** (0.024)
Num.Obs.	390	382	443	438
R2	0.246	0.296	0.021	0.053
President elected unopposed				
(Intercept)	0.434*** (0.039)	0.575*** (0.134)	0.390*** (0.034)	0.624*** (0.140)
Direct election	-0.306*** (0.045)	-0.303*** (0.047)	-0.262*** (0.040)	-0.243*** (0.040)
Num.Obs.	393	385	444	439
R2	0.120	0.144	0.091	0.144

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each informal capture outcome on direct election (Except the administrative record outcomes). The left column does so for the first transition, and the right column for the second transition. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

D.2.3 Robustness 2: Quotas

This appendix analyses the outcomes from Figure 5 in the main paper in the context of quotas in two ways. Tables D.11 and D.12 do so by estimating the same regressions that underlie Figure 5 in the main paper among three subsets of the village councils from the sample: those with the president seat reserved for women (left column), those with the president seat reserved for OBCs/open (middle column), those with the president seat reserved for SCs (right column). Tables D.13 and D.14 compare the impact of direct election for each outcome to the impact of gender quotas and SC quotas.

Table D.11: The impact of direct election on formal capture, by quotas

	Gender-reserved seats	OBC/Open seats	SC-reserved seats
President Maratha			
(Intercept)	0.215*** (0.030)	0.345*** (0.030)	0.000 (0.000)
Direct election	0.109* (0.055)	0.139** (0.050)	0.000 (0.000)
Num.Obs.	291	408	194
R2	0.014	0.019	
Proportion land held by president's caste in village			
(Intercept)	0.310*** (0.026)	0.403*** (0.023)	0.091*** (0.010)
Direct election	0.129** (0.044)	0.147*** (0.036)	0.100** (0.031)
Num.Obs.	185	253	129
R2	0.048	0.064	0.101
President owns pacca house			
(Intercept)	0.505*** (0.037)	0.558*** (0.032)	0.413*** (0.045)
Direct election	0.127* (0.060)	0.111* (0.049)	0.094 (0.074)
Num.Obs.	292	409	194
R2	0.015	0.012	0.008
President owns three/four-wheeler			
(Intercept)	0.177*** (0.028)	0.213*** (0.026)	0.074** (0.024)
Direct election	0.172** (0.054)	0.112* (0.045)	0.131* (0.053)
Num.Obs.	292	409	194
R2	0.037	0.016	0.037
President landed			
(Intercept)	0.212*** (0.030)	0.408*** (0.031)	0.183*** (0.035)
Direct election	0.093+ (0.054)	0.149** (0.051)	0.150* (0.066)
Num.Obs.	289	403	192
R2	0.011	0.021	0.029
President male			
(Intercept)	0.000 (0.000)	0.357*** (0.030)	0.355*** (0.044)
Direct election	0.000 (0.000)	0.168*** (0.050)	0.138+ (0.073)
Num.Obs.	292	409	194
R2		0.027	0.018

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each formal capture outcome on direct election. The left column does so among gender-reserved seats, the middle column for OBC/Open seats, and the right column for SC-reserved seats. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

Table D.12: The impact of direct election on informal capture, by quotas

	Gender-reserved seats	OBC/Open seats	SC-reserved seats
Citizen reports former president/other villager leads village events			
(Intercept)	0.209*** (0.015)	0.206*** (0.013)	0.203*** (0.017)
Direct election	-0.034 (0.023)	-0.073*** (0.018)	-0.021 (0.027)
Num.Obs.	1702	2389	1141
R2	0.002	0.009	0.001
Citizen nominated former president/other villager as village representative to bureaucrat			
(Intercept)	0.172*** (0.014)	0.158*** (0.011)	0.186*** (0.017)
Direct election	-0.037+ (0.021)	-0.053*** (0.016)	-0.050+ (0.026)
Num.Obs.	1725	2437	1160
R2	0.002	0.006	0.004
President reports rich landowner influences council			
(Intercept)	0.140*** (0.026)	0.123*** (0.021)	0.147*** (0.033)
Direct election	-0.060 (0.037)	-0.091*** (0.025)	-0.064 (0.046)
Num.Obs.	280	398	189
R2	0.008	0.025	0.009
Resignation filed: Administrative data			
(Intercept)	0.173*** (0.020)	0.223*** (0.016)	0.026 (0.018)
Direct election	-0.102*** (0.026)	-0.158*** (0.020)	0.030 (0.037)
Num.Obs.	579	1061	129
R2	0.021	0.045	0.006
Citizen reports resignation			
(Intercept)	0.215*** (0.025)	0.263*** (0.024)	0.101*** (0.022)
Direct election	-0.202*** (0.027)	-0.233*** (0.026)	-0.071** (0.026)
Num.Obs.	1711	2415	1157
R2	0.078	0.091	0.018
President reports resignation			
(Intercept)	0.237*** (0.031)	0.306*** (0.029)	0.083** (0.025)
Direct election	-0.218*** (0.034)	-0.294*** (0.031)	-0.028 (0.037)
Num.Obs.	291	406	194
R2	0.082	0.132	0.003
President elected unopposed			
(Intercept)	0.438*** (0.037)	0.440*** (0.032)	0.347*** (0.043)
Direct election	-0.259*** (0.052)	-0.315*** (0.041)	-0.210*** (0.059)
Num.Obs.	291	408	194
R2	0.069	0.109	0.053

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each informal capture outcome on direct election. The left column does so among gender-reserved seats, the middle column for OBC/Open seats, and the right column for SC-reserved seats. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

Table D.13: Benchmarking the impact of direct election on formal capture

	Impact of direct	Impact of gender quota	Impact of SC quota
President Maratha			
(Intercept)	0.232*** (0.022)	0.285*** (0.026)	0.399*** (0.024)
Direct election	0.098** (0.038)		
Gender quota		-0.031 (0.036)	
SC quota			-0.399*** (0.024)
Num.Obs.	603	603	603
R2	0.012	0.001	0.176
Proportion land held by president's caste in village			
(Intercept)	0.289*** (0.018)	0.349*** (0.022)	0.471*** (0.018)
Direct election	0.154*** (0.031)		
Gender quota		0.015 (0.031)	
SC quota			-0.341*** (0.023)
Num.Obs.	382	382	382
R2	0.065	0.001	0.290
President owns pacca house			
(Intercept)	0.511*** (0.026)	0.551*** (0.028)	0.600*** (0.024)
Direct election	0.105* (0.041)		
Gender quota		0.000 (0.041)	
SC quota			-0.152*** (0.043)
Num.Obs.	604	604	604
R2	0.010	0.000	0.020
President owns three/four-wheeler			
(Intercept)	0.168*** (0.019)	0.189*** (0.022)	0.256*** (0.022)
Direct election	0.119*** (0.035)		
Gender quota		0.051 (0.033)	
SC quota			-0.132*** (0.032)
Num.Obs.	604	604	604
R2	0.020	0.004	0.023
President landed			
(Intercept)	0.334*** (0.025)	0.534*** (0.029)	0.468*** (0.025)
Direct election	0.155*** (0.041)		
Gender quota		-0.289*** (0.038)	
SC quota			-0.228*** (0.040)
Num.Obs.	596	596	596
R2	0.024	0.087	0.048
President male			
(Intercept)	0.357*** (0.025)	0.811*** (0.022)	0.424*** (0.024)
Direct election	0.160*** (0.041)		
Gender quota		-0.811*** (0.022)	
SC quota			-0.017 (0.043)
Num.Obs.	604	604	604
R2	0.025	0.675	0.000

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each formal capture outcome on either direct election, gender quota, or SC quota. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

Table D.14: Benchmarking the impact of direct election on informal capture

	Impact of direct	Impact of gender quota	Impact of SC quota
Citizen reports former president/other villager leads village events			
(Intercept)	0.205*** (0.011)	0.170*** (0.011)	0.177*** (0.010)
Direct election	-0.057*** (0.015)		
Gender quota		0.027+ (0.016)	
SC quota			0.018 (0.017)
Num.Obs.	3536	3536	3536
R2	0.005	0.001	0.000
Citizen nominated former president/other villager as village representative to bureaucrat			
(Intercept)	0.168*** (0.009)	0.137*** (0.009)	0.138*** (0.008)
Direct election	-0.052*** (0.014)		
Gender quota		0.022 (0.014)	
SC quota			0.029+ (0.015)
Num.Obs.	3603	3603	3603
R2	0.005	0.001	0.001
President reports rich landowner influences council			
(Intercept)	0.131*** (0.018)	0.081*** (0.016)	0.088*** (0.014)
Direct election	-0.083*** (0.023)		
Gender quota		0.037 (0.025)	
SC quota			0.034 (0.028)
Num.Obs.	588	588	588
R2	0.018	0.004	0.003
Resignation filed: Administrative data			
(Intercept)	0.193*** (0.014)	0.140*** (0.012)	0.151*** (0.011)
Direct election	-0.138*** (0.017)		
Gender quota		-0.008 (0.019)	
SC quota			-0.112*** (0.020)
Num.Obs.	1366	1357	1267
R2	0.039	0.000	0.010
Citizen reports resignation			
(Intercept)	0.210*** (0.018)	0.138*** (0.016)	0.171*** (0.016)
Direct election	-0.180*** (0.020)		
Gender quota		0.003 (0.024)	
SC quota			-0.098*** (0.022)
Num.Obs.	3578	3578	3578
R2	0.064	0.000	0.017
President reports resignation			
(Intercept)	0.233*** (0.022)	0.148*** (0.020)	0.192*** (0.020)
Direct election	-0.207*** (0.024)		
Gender quota		0.010 (0.029)	
SC quota			-0.119*** (0.027)
Num.Obs.	601	601	601
R2	0.078	0.000	0.024
President elected unopposed			
(Intercept)	0.409*** (0.026)	0.260*** (0.025)	0.315*** (0.023)
Direct election	-0.281*** (0.034)		
Gender quota		0.084* (0.037)	
SC quota			-0.047 (0.039)
Num.Obs.	603	603	603
R2	0.089	0.008	0.002

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each informal capture outcome on either direct election, gender quota, or SC quota. All regressions use cluster robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

D.2.4 Robustness 3: Controlling for observables

Table D.15: The impact of direct election on formal elite capture, with controls

	Formal capture measures					
	President Maratha	Proportion land held by president's caste in village	President owns pacca house	President owns three/four- wheeler	President landed	President male
(Intercept)	0.624*** (0.108)	0.533*** (0.079)	0.614*** (0.125)	0.049 (0.084)	0.414** (0.130)	0.818*** (0.064)
Direct election	0.106** (0.033)	0.142*** (0.025)	0.107** (0.041)	0.128*** (0.036)	0.133*** (0.039)	0.113*** (0.021)
No. villages	-0.068*** (0.019)	-0.004 (0.016)	0.011 (0.031)	-0.005 (0.025)	-0.011 (0.028)	0.021+ (0.011)
Population	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000* (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
Percent SC pop.	-0.316* (0.129)	-0.178+ (0.102)	-0.069 (0.169)	0.018 (0.140)	-0.055 (0.155)	0.033 (0.074)
Distance to block (km)	0.000 (0.001)	0.003* (0.001)	-0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.002 (0.002)	-0.000 (0.001)
Time to block (hr)	-0.014*** (0.003)	0.001 (0.019)	-0.024** (0.009)	-0.013* (0.006)	-0.010 (0.007)	-0.002 (0.002)
Speed to block (km/hr)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000** (0.000)	0.000** (0.000)
Pilgrimage sites	-0.003 (0.035)	-0.028 (0.026)	0.036 (0.044)	0.034 (0.038)	-0.011 (0.042)	0.001 (0.024)
Historic sites	0.023 (0.057)	0.015 (0.033)	0.115+ (0.062)	0.070 (0.057)	0.084 (0.063)	0.013 (0.034)
Economic opportunities	0.043 (0.038)	0.001 (0.029)	0.067 (0.046)	0.003 (0.040)	0.013 (0.043)	0.062* (0.024)
Electricity grid	-0.008 (0.097)	-0.086 (0.066)	-0.051 (0.109)	0.118 (0.073)	0.132 (0.115)	-0.068 (0.052)
Gender quota	-0.031 (0.032)	0.026 (0.024)	-0.002 (0.040)	0.052 (0.034)	-0.281*** (0.038)	-0.815*** (0.022)
OBC caste quota	-0.221*** (0.047)	-0.142*** (0.034)	-0.024 (0.049)	-0.032 (0.044)	-0.028 (0.048)	-0.006 (0.026)
SC caste quota	-0.505*** (0.034)	-0.399*** (0.027)	-0.170*** (0.049)	-0.146*** (0.038)	-0.254*** (0.044)	-0.030 (0.028)
Num.Obs.	593	380	594	594	587	594
R2	0.267	0.409	0.062	0.061	0.169	0.709

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each formal capture outcome on direct election and controls from Figure 3 in the main paper. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

Table D.16: The impact of direct election on informal elite capture, with controls

	Informal capture measures					
	Citizen reports former president/other villager leads village events	Citizen nominated former president/other villager as village representative to bureaucrat	President reports rich landowner influences council	Citizen reports resignation	President reports resignation	President elected unopposed
(Intercept)	0.191*** (0.034)	0.143** (0.043)	0.012 (0.060)	0.252*** (0.062)	0.223** (0.078)	0.658*** (0.112)
Direct election	-0.061*** (0.015)	-0.051*** (0.014)	-0.081*** (0.023)	-0.174*** (0.020)	-0.201*** (0.025)	-0.270*** (0.035)
No. villages	0.019 (0.012)	0.018+ (0.010)	-0.010 (0.017)	-0.014 (0.012)	-0.005 (0.017)	-0.046* (0.021)
Population	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
Percent SC pop.	-0.179** (0.062)	-0.007 (0.054)	0.225+ (0.119)	-0.022 (0.106)	-0.146 (0.108)	-0.122 (0.158)
Distance to block (km)	-0.000 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.001)	-0.002+ (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)	0.002 (0.002)
Time to block (hr)	0.005 (0.013)	-0.003 (0.002)	-0.003 (0.004)	0.004 (0.007)	-0.001 (0.003)	-0.009 (0.009)
Speed to block (km/hr)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
Pilgrimage sites	-0.011 (0.018)	-0.006 (0.016)	0.018 (0.030)	0.057* (0.025)	0.072* (0.032)	-0.016 (0.040)
Historic sites	0.046+ (0.025)	0.015 (0.026)	0.022 (0.045)	0.029 (0.040)	-0.005 (0.048)	0.035 (0.061)
Economic opportunities	0.001 (0.018)	-0.010 (0.017)	0.028 (0.031)	0.058* (0.029)	0.109** (0.036)	0.037 (0.042)
Electricity grid	-0.010 (0.027)	-0.008 (0.038)	0.043 (0.050)	0.037 (0.052)	0.063 (0.075)	-0.235* (0.101)
Gender quota	0.026+ (0.016)	0.022 (0.014)	0.028 (0.025)	-0.003 (0.022)	0.003 (0.028)	0.079* (0.036)
OBC caste quota	0.021 (0.020)	0.007 (0.017)	0.041 (0.030)	-0.103*** (0.029)	-0.064+ (0.036)	-0.036 (0.044)
SC caste quota	0.020 (0.018)	0.031+ (0.018)	0.051+ (0.030)	-0.147*** (0.027)	-0.155*** (0.034)	-0.061 (0.044)
Num.Obs.	3481	3544	579	3523	591	593
R2	0.014	0.011	0.041	0.126	0.150	0.123

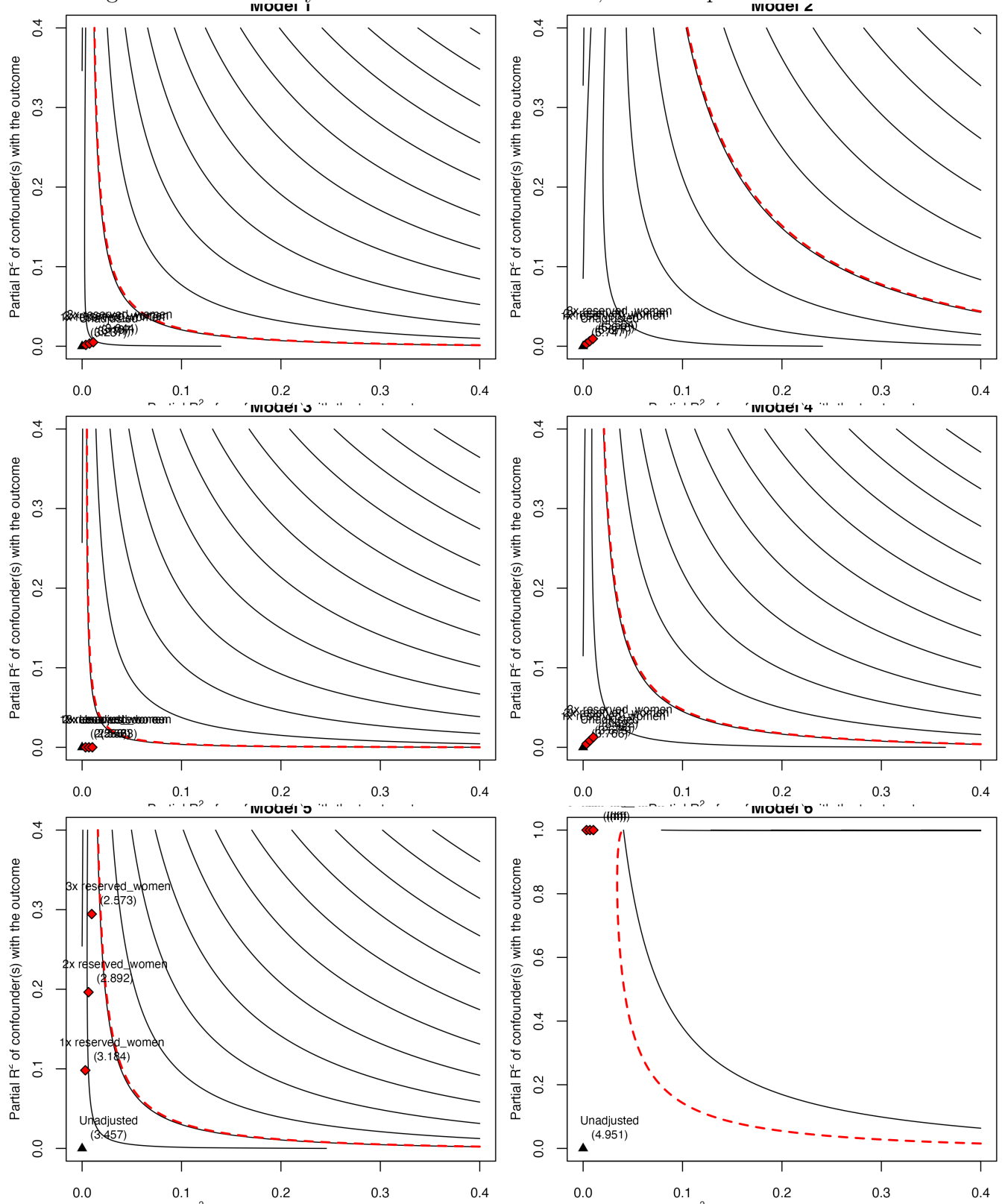
+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each informal capture outcome on direct election and controls from Figure 3 in the main paper. All regressions use robust standard errors. Outcomes from the citizen survey use cluster robust standard errors at the council level.

D.2.5 Robustness 4: Probing the role of unobservables through sensitivity analysis

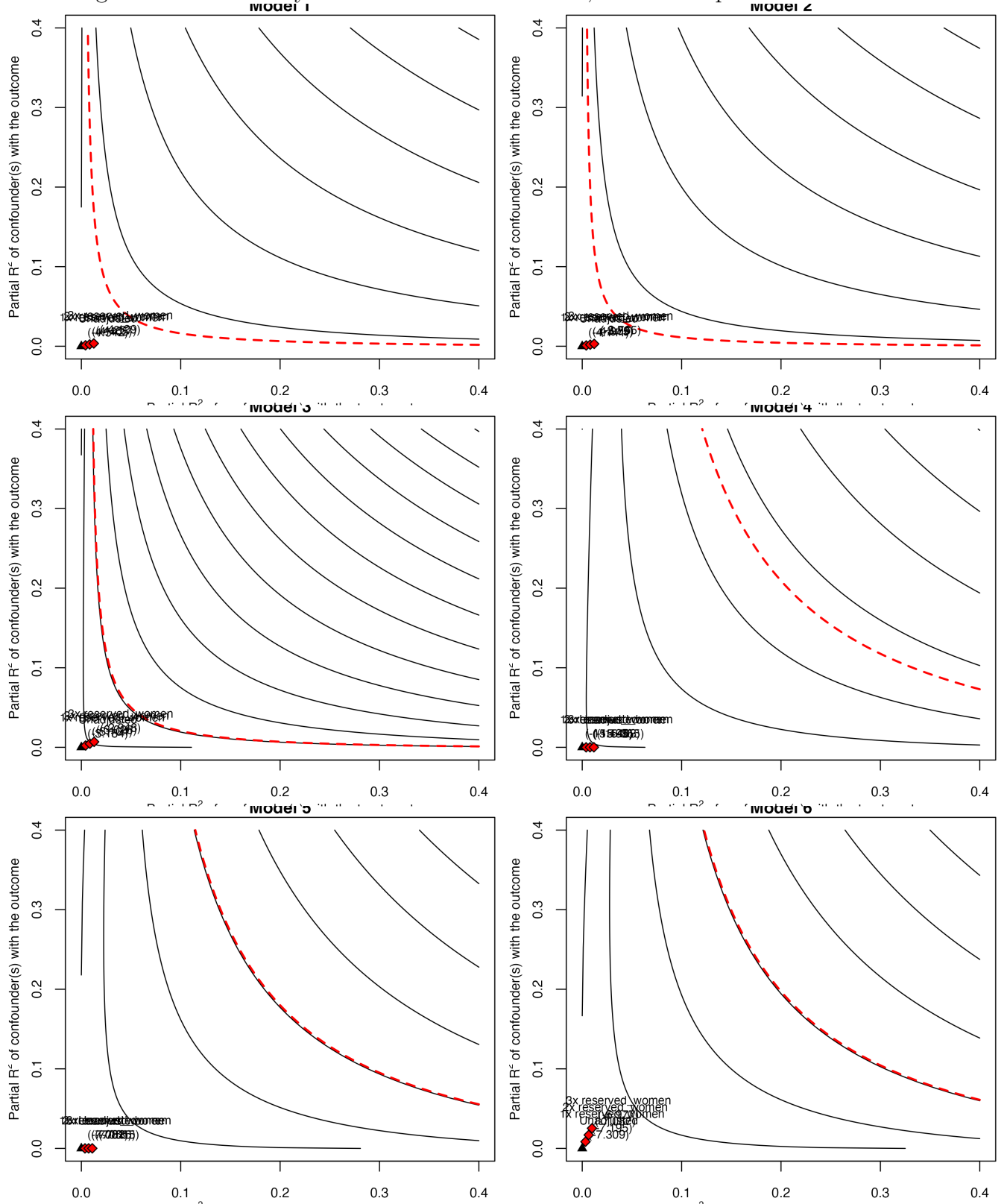
I use the `sensemakr` package in R, developed by Cinelli and Hazlett (2020) to probe the role unobservables could play in confounding effects. Figures D.2 and D.3 below plot the sensitivity of the t -values associated with the estimates of effects (for informal and formal capture outcomes, using linear regressions with controls), using the gender quota variable as a benchmark to understand how strong unobservables would have to be to significantly change the interpretation of this paper’s results. In the plots below, the red line indicates a t -value of 2, the conventional approximate value for 95 % confidence intervals. Each of the red dots plots hypothetical unobserved confounders as strong as, twice as strong as, and three times as strong as the gender quota variable. For each of the outcomes, the plots demonstrate that unobserved confounders would have to have more than three times the strength than the gender quota variable for the results of this paper to become statistically insignificant. This seems implausible, as gender quotas are extremely theoretically and empirically important in this context in terms of explaining authority outcomes.

Figure D.2: Sensitivity of t-value to unobservables, formal capture outcomes



Note: Each figure plots the sensitivity of the t -value of each coefficient estimate of each formal capture outcome to unobserved confounders, using gender quotas as a benchmark.

Figure D.3: Sensitivity of t-value to unobservables, informal capture outcomes



Note: Each figure plots the sensitivity of the t -value of each coefficient estimate of each informal capture outcome to unobserved confounders, using gender quotas as a benchmark.

D.2.6 Robustness 5: Resignation follow-up interviews

To determine whether resignation was due to elite influence (or other reasons), semi-structured follow-up phone interviews were conducted with all presidents in the survey that reported an intention to resign ($N = 92$). 87 out of 92 responded, a response rate of 95 %. Interviews lasted on average about 15 minutes each. Structured questions included are below, and unstructured follow-up questions were asked to probe additional details.

1. Did you resign from your position as president? If so, for how many years did you serve? How many other people served as president, and for how many years each?
2. Please share a little bit about the reasons you decided to resign from your position. Was anyone else involved in this decision besides you? If so, who were the main decision-makers around your resignation? When and where was the decision taken?
3. Is there anything else you would like to share about the decision to resign and your experience as village council president?

Out of the 87 presidents who responded, 71 (around 82 %) shared that influential villagers were those that decided they would resign and the conditions of their resignation. In many instances, presidents expanded on this, sharing that elders or “big people” in the village temple meeting made these decisions. One president’s remark is particularly illuminating: “This system of sharing the tenure is completely inappropriate. I want to work for people but six months are not enough. It is the *bhauki-gavki* (important villagers) in the villages that forces and establishes such systems of resignation. When I became president and started generating interest, I had to resign because I gave my word.” Table D.17 documents the interview responses from all of the interviews.

Table D.17: Resignation follow-up interviews

Index	President order	Who decided?	Time spent in office	No. people in the same tenure	Other notes
1	2	>3 children	2	2	5-6 “prabhavi ani anubhavi” (influential and experienced) people decided
2	2	collector invalidated president’s candidacy	3.5	2	
3	1	disqualified because of corruption			
4	2	Faced harassment	3	2	
5	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	
6	1	influential villagers	4	2	
7	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	
8	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	
9	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	

10	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	In temple meeting pre-election
11	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	
12	3	influential villagers	3	3	
13	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	Patil decided Temple meeting decision
14	1	influential villagers	2	3	
15	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	
16	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	“Gavatil anubhavi mandali tharavete sagala”, The experienced group of people in the village decide everything.
17	3	influential villagers	2	3	
18	1	influential villagers	1	2	
19	2	influential villagers	4	2	“Bhukitlyach lokani dabaw anyawar mag kay karaycha?” When people from the bhauki pressure you, what can one do?
20	3	influential villagers	3	3	
21	1	influential villagers	1.5		
22	4	influential villagers	1	4	“Gavatil jeshtmandalichya margdarshanakhali nivadnu-kiche nirnay amachya gavat hotat”; In our village, election decisions are taken only with the guidance of the elders in the village.
23	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	
24	2	influential villagers	3	3	
25	5	influential villagers	1	5	“Gavatil Vayaskar Mandali nirnay ghetla”; The group of elderly villagers took the decision.
26	2	influential villagers	1	2	Senior Citizens (“Vayaskar lok”) decided
27	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	

28	3	influential villagers	2	3	Bhauki People decided it in temple meeting
29	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	
30	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	
31	3	influential villagers	3	3	Influential people (village leaders) in the village decided ("gavaltil pudhari")
32	2	influential villagers	1	7	
33	4	influential villagers	1	5	
34	3	influential villagers	2	3	
35	7	influential villagers	1.5	7	"Jeshtha Mandali"; the group of elderly villagers decided
36	3	influential villagers	2	3	
37	3	influential villagers	3	3	
38	2	influential villagers	2	3	
39	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	
40	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	Decided in the temple Influential and senior citizens decided in temple meeting
41	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	
42	2	influential villagers	1	4	
43	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	Senior Citizens ("Gavatil Jeshta mandali") in temple meeting all the bhauki members in the temple meeting before election All the senior citizens in front of whole village in temple meeting
44	3	influential villagers	2	3	
45	2	influential villagers	1	4	
46	3	influential villagers	1	3	Decided in the temple Bhauki People decided among themselves
47	5	influential villagers	1	5	
48	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	
49	3	influential villagers	2	3	In temple meeting pre-election All the Bhauki people decided in the temple meeting before the election.
50	4	influential villagers	1	4	
					Patil Saheb decided

51		influential villagers	2.5	2	Temple meeting decision
52	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	Senior citizens who villagers respect (“Mhatare loka jyana gav wale mantat”)
53	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	Before the election, it was decided between both bhauki groups to share the sarpanch position for 2.5 years.
54	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	
55	5	influential villagers	1	5	Influential people (“gavatle pudhari je samor samor astat”); The leaders in the village who are come before everyone else the important (big people) people from the village decided it before the election. (“Gavatlte mothe loka astat tyni nivadnuki adhi tharval hota bagha”)
56	4	influential villagers	1	4	
57	1	influential villagers	2.5	4	Important people of the village decided among themselves (“Gavatil Pramukh Mandali aply-aplyat tharvatat”)
58	3	influential villagers	2	3	Decided in the temple
59	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	Their village has Sidheswar temple where the Meetings occur and two bhaukis decide.
60	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	Elders in the bhauki decided
61	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	
62	2	influential villagers	2.5	2	

63	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	“Bhaukitil Mandali + Mothi Mandali” decided; The group of big people and bhauki people
64	2	influential villagers	0.5	5	
65	1	influential villagers	1	5	“This system of sharing the tenure is completely inappropriate. I want to work for people but six months are not enough. It is the Bhauki-Gavki in the villages that forces and establishes such systems of resignation. when I became sarpanch and started generating interest, I had to resign because I gave my word.”
66	1	influential villagers	2		
67	1	influential villagers	1		
68	1	influential villagers	1	3	“anubhavi ani jankar”; those with experience and knowledge
69	1	influential villagers	1	5	
70	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	
71	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	
72	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	
73	1	influential villagers	2	3	
74	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	
75	1	influential villagers	2.5	2	
76	1	job opportunity	3	2	
77	2	no confidence motion			
78	1	no confidence motion			
79	2	no confidence motion			
80	1	ward members	2.5	2	
81	3	ward members	1.5	3	
82	1	ward members	2.5	2	
83	2	ward members	2.5	2	
84	3	ward members	2	2	
85	4	ward members	2	4	

86	2	ward members	2.5	2	
87	4	ward members	1	4	

D.2.7 Robustness 6: Additional qualitative evidence

This appendix documents additional qualitative evidence from the first round of theory-testing fieldwork that complements the empirical analyses in the main paper.

Informal elite capture in indirect elections: If someone wants to be considered for the post who is not the traditional elites' preferred candidate, one president explained, "the seniors will request them to withdraw." Another president described in detail how traditional elites dominated elections in his village: "They're in the age range of 60-70. They have a lot of experience... they act separately from the actual voting. If I become member and you want to become a member too, they'll tell you to step aside for now, that they'll give you a chance next time. They'll convince you that I'll be a better choice for now... So they can make people wait and listen to them." "There was no competition left. 31st was the last day to submit an application to rescind the form. After that there were 2 forms [for the post]: mine and [another potential candidate's]. They requested him to rescind his form by the 4th, and on the 4th he went and got his form rescinded. And then on the 4th, I got elected unopposed." In short, traditional elites can craft *ex ante* who makes up the body via persuasion (or coercion), and, in turn, can guarantee that who they prefer to be president is eventually chosen.⁹

Coordinated resignations occur when traditional village elites persuade or coerce council presidents into forfeiting their office via a formal resignation. The "temple coalitions" of "village elders" convene in an "unofficial meeting" and decide who will serve as the council president, and for how long. When elites use this tactic, typically the term for the council president post is divided between, at minimum, 2 people, and at maximum, 17 people. In one village, the council president described, the village elites, "political heavyweights in [the] village," "sat the 6 of us down and gave each of us a tenure of around 10 months." This implied that each president held office for 10 months, and resigned once their 10 months were over. Presidents described lacking the agency to resist this system, which suggests that the resignations need not be totally voluntary. In all the interviews I conducted with council presidents, none characterized themselves as taking part in the decision to resign. Unanimously, they expressed a lack of ability to challenge village elites, acknowledging an acceptance of the reality of the system.¹⁰

One senses a feeling of disempowerment when speaking to the presidents who had to end their time short. At the end of most interviews, I asked presidents to speak broadly about their experience in office. One president responded: "It was nice... I learned a lot. [Before coming into office] I didn't know much beyond the household."¹¹ [But] now, it's all gone backwards." She and others were frank about the fact that a "backwards effect" (in Marathi: *ulta parinam*) occurs: one gets just enough time in office to learn, but not enough time to transform their status. Another president criticized the system of forced resignations: "There are no benefits, it's a complete loss... There is no [work that gets done] because [a president] needs at least 6 months to learn about the work to be done." Yet another president, forced to share her tenure with 5 others, recounted: "I didn't get to learn much, because I didn't have much time. If I'd had more time, I would have gained more experience. I made

⁹Interviews by author on 25 June and 3 July 2022.

¹⁰Interviews by author in Amravati district on 20 May Pune district on 23-25 June 2022.

¹¹Interview by author on 23 June 2022.

do with the experience I got... at least one and a half years will allow [the president] to immerse himself in the [post]. Nothing happens in six months. How much can happen in such a short period?”¹²

Many presidents are aware of the underlying rationale of coordinated resignations. One president was particularly frank in describing what happens in their village, and why¹³:

“[The presidents] share the post... When the elections are announced, a meeting is conducted at the village level. It’s not official. First it is conducted at the village level, and the official one is held later... Men from all 3 wards meet – the important and senior people – and they decide. When they coordinate resignations, *they benefit from the transfer of the post that happens during sharing. They get to claim and hold leverage over people later because they have helped that person get the post of sarpanch, or get into the gram panchayat. But the candidates don’t realize that.* Honestly, there is no village development as a result of this, and progress is slowed because having 10 sarpanchs in 5 years means that no one can understand how to help the village develop, can they?”¹⁴

When asked if he would have wanted to remain the president if given the opportunity, one village council president stated “I would have...I would have been able to give more time to the village...The village would have transformed completely, because you can get a lot of work done in 5 years. When you have the post for a year, you spend 6 months just learning about everything: who needs to be sent which documents, whose signature is needed where, how to handle official documents...”¹⁵

Coordinated resignations are employed by local elites throughout Maharashtra. Local-level and state-level politicians were forthright in acknowledging its reach. When I asked a council president if he was aware of this practice in other areas than his own, he explained that it happens across districts, and is not unique to particular political parties.¹⁶ Another council president seconded this view, stating that “it’s in all of the villages...” The former Chief Minister of Maharashtra shared that this is an age-old system prevalent throughout the state for decades. State and local bureaucrats across Maharashtra admitted that this occurs, but were often clear in stating that these arrangements are “informal” and “among the villagers themselves,” shirking responsibility of the system. Other bureaucrats and civil society actors admonished the practice, stating its deleterious effects on local democracy, political equality and development.¹⁷

¹²Interviews by author on 21 June and 25 June.

¹³Interview by author on 9 July 2022.

¹⁴Emphasis mine.

¹⁵Interview by author on 25 June 2022.

¹⁶Interview by author on 25 June 2022.

¹⁷Interviews by author on 16 June-10 July 2022.

D.3 Alternative explanations

Another reason we may see a boost in the *de facto* authority of the president when she is directly elected is because of the changing role of party involvement under the two types of elections. Table D.18 below shows that, at least in this context, this logic does not explain authority differentials. Column 1 shows that presidents who are directly elected report levels of party support that are statistically indistinguishable from presidents who are indirectly elected. Nor do directly elected presidents report receiving higher levels of party encouragement to contest elections or party support in mobilizing voters when compared to their indirect counterparts (Columns 2-3). Columns 4 and 5 demonstrate that directly elected presidents are also not differentially likely to be a member of a party or have worked for a party.

In addition, one reason why we may expect direct elections to be more contested (and have less instances of presidents elected in unopposed elections) is that they are higher-stakes in general. In other words, unopposed elections under indirect elections may not indicate undue elite influence, but rather lower-stakes elections with less attention drawn toward them. As a potential test of this, I probe whether citizens are more likely to vote – as a proxy for the attention the election garners – under direct and indirect elections and find no significant differences (Column 1 of Table D.19 below). Plus, according to this logic, we would expect to see *fewer* unopposed elections in indirect elections (higher political competition), because there may be fewer barriers to entry for candidates than direct elections. The analyses in the main paper shows the opposite: elections with a lower barrier to entry in fact have higher rates of unopposed elections, which, I argue and qualitative evidence suggests, may be in part due to elite coordination to fix the pool of executives.

Table D.19 also provides evidence that citizens in directly elected villages are not more likely to support the BJP or Congress (the state’s main parties at the time of study) than indirectly elected villages.

Table D.18: Alternative explanations: President party support

	President reports having received party support	President reports party encourage- ment to contest	President reports party mobilized voters	President member of political party	President party worker previously
(Intercept)	0.095*** (0.015)	0.014* (0.006)	0.151*** (0.019)	0.057*** (0.012)	0.136*** (0.018)
Direct election	-0.026 (0.022)	-0.001 (0.010)	0.024 (0.031)	-0.005 (0.019)	0.036 (0.031)
Num.Obs.	604	603	604	604	601
R2	0.002	0.000	0.001	0.000	0.002
R2 Adj.	0.000	-0.002	-0.001	-0.002	0.001

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Regression of outcomes on direct election indicator with robust standard errors.
Citizen voting outcome uses robust standard errors clustered at the council level.

Table D.19: Alternative explanations: Citizen voting behavior

	Citizen voted in village council election	Citizen prefers BJP	Citizen prefers Congress
(Intercept)	0.898*** (0.008)	0.186*** (0.011)	0.304*** (0.013)
Direct election	0.012 (0.012)	-0.008 (0.017)	-0.030 (0.021)
Num.Obs.	3650	3408	3408
R2	0.000	0.000	0.001
R2 Adj.	0.000	-0.000	0.001

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Regression of outcomes on direct election indicator with robust standard errors. Citizen voting outcome uses robust standard errors clustered at the council level.

E Additional case comparison evidence

In this Appendix, I synthesize of all of the case comparisons in non-SC-reserved seats I conducted in the second phase of confirmatory qualitative research.

Table E.1: Synthesis of case comparisons in open seats

Council	Election type	Informal capture	Formal capture	<i>De facto</i> authority of president
1	Indirect	Y	N	Low
2	Indirect	Y	N	Low
3	Direct	N	Y	High
4	Direct	N	Y	High

Village council 1. Village council 1 (indirect) showed explicit signs of informal capture through: pre-election coordination in temple meetings, coordinated resignations, and post-election influence from local elites. The socially subordinate council president exhibited low levels of *de facto* authority, while unelected elites made decisions in his place.

- Pre-election coordination:
 - Influential person 1: “we all influential people decide who will contest among ourselves by discussions. In short, Father body decides all.”
 - Influential person 2: “to ensure that everyone gets fair representation, each bhavki fields one candidate in the election”
 - Female citizen 1: “just to maintain the social status of the Bhauki, they elect people in the body unopposed. what else other than this? In Mahashivratri meeting, they decide who will fill the forms. Around 10-15 forms are submitted. Some people get disqualified. Later they decide whether to have election or do continue with unopposed system. They decided among themselves.”
- Coordinated resignations:
 - Influential person 1: “Everyone is given the chance because there are many aspiring candidates. If we don’t give them the chance, conflicts are bound to emerge. And you know if there are two people willing to work for their village and only one of them gets opportunity to work for five years, the other gets disappointed. In short, to ensure the village harmony and justice to everyone, such kind of systems work.”
 - Male citizen 2: “Giving the position to one person reduces the importance of the influential people. That’s why they decide to share the term.”
 - President: “The elders in the village take all such decisions regarding resignations.”
- Post-election elite influence:

- Male citizen 1: “In this village, only those few people rule. People listen to them because he might own land, have money, exert influence, or have connections outside.”
- President: “the elderly people in the village who are always at the fore front for in any work related to village decide this”
- Influential person 1: “it’s been 35 years. Our village has one fund and I used to look after all the documentation related work of that fund. How much money should be given to the temple construction and for festivals, I take care of all this. Till date I take all the decisions.”
- Bhauki leader attended BDO meeting instead of president, attended our private interview with the president
- Low *de facto* authority of president:
 - Influential person 2: “Don’t think that only the Sarpanch does all the work. The people backing the Sarpanch do most of the work. Because even if a new Sarpanch comes in, it takes almost two years just to learn. In such cases, the village leaders, who have experience, help out. Because they know everything. The Sarpanch and Up-Sarpanch have remained just for names in our village.”
 - Male citizen 1: “[the elites] control things because after all the elected members are their men. If I’m powerful and made you president, still control remains in my hand.”

Village council 2. Village council 2 (indirect) showed explicit signs of informal capture through: pre-election coordination in temple meetings, coordinated resignations, and post-election influence from local elites. The socially subordinate council president exhibited low levels of *de facto* authority, while unelected elites made decisions in her place.

- Pre-election coordination:
 - Influential person 1: “I do decide [what will happen in elections]. I am always there for every election, in the meetings, and during the decision-making process. In 2021, I supported a woman candidate from the neighboring village.”
 - Male citizen 1: “yes, we have such a group in our village [that decides election matters]. Every village has such people.”
 - Male citizen 2: “They work behind the scenes. Earlier they were visible but now they are not.”
 - President: “[The influential people] decide in the veranda of a temple, some people come to your home.”
- Coordinated resignations:
 - Former president 1: “the elderly people in the village are always at the fore front for in any work related to village decide who will serve, resign, and when... These elder people sit in front of the temple and have discussions.”

- Influential person 1: “At the village level it is good because it helps minimize conflicts...but the presidents are in name only, what else?”
- Post-election elite influence:
 - Influential person 1: “yes, people do pressurise or interfere in decision of president.”
- Low *de facto* authority of president:
 - Influential person 1: “She doesn’t even come to the office or meetings, so how can she have control over the administration? She is just for the sake of name and for doing signature.”

Village council 3. On the other hand, pre-election coordination among elites broke down in village council 3 (direct). Instead, well-established landowning elites ran for office, and the strongest among the factions won. The president commanded significant *de facto* authority once in office.

- Temple elites running for office
 - President: “before 2017, for 20 years my two-uncle and my father influenced politics for 20 years. At that time there were no opposed elections. Opposed elections have started only from 2017 direct election. Since 1978, only two times we had opposed election: 2017 and 2023.” “Yes, an election happened because now things have changed. Now, elections have become more common, and divisions in the village have started to form.” “If it’s a village matter, it was discussed in the temple. Even decisions like choosing the president used to be made in the temple. Yes, experienced people suggest who should stand. This is the method our village follows.”
 - Village council bureaucrat: “What happens is that 30 percent of the people are pushed forward, and 70 percent remain neglected. There are better people than the current president’s family, but they are suppressed and never come forward. In the last election, the president coaxed a member to defect, and they won the election. It’s all just for show.”
- High *de facto* authority of president
 - President: “The directly electly president gets more power. In indirect election, tenure of the president used to get divided. Someone used to get 1 year or another person would get 1 year. When the president changes in indirect elections, a lot of things like we need to change name on bank accounts, official documents, etc. But in direct elections, such disruptions don’t occur.”
 - Female citizen 1: “They (president and his Family) are more dominating and superior. President is someone who can intimidate or bully people.”
 - Village council bureaucrat: “The president acts on his whims and fancies.”

- In observing a village-wide meeting, we saw the president command significant authority via leading the meeting, calling on people to speak, speaking louder and more frequently than the others in the room, and interrupting others or telling them to be seated.

Village council 4. Pre-election coordination among elites broke down in village council 4 (direct). Instead, well-established landowning elites ran for office, and the strongest among the factions won. The president commanded significant *de facto* authority once in office.

- Pre-election coordination breakdown

- Male citizen 1: “For almost 40 years, [the village elites] have ruled this village.”
- Village council bureaucrat: “such presidents [who resign] are only for the sake of name. They don’t have anything to do with village development. This system was prevalent during indirect elections in our village.”
- Influential person 1: “Our village used to be conflict-free thanks to unopposed elections. Everyone used to live together.”
- President: “There are 5 wadis. When there is an election, a meeting is conducted between all the five wadis to decide who should be made members in unopposed elections. But now, for the president seat, we have opposed elections.”

- Temple elites running for office

- Male citizen 1: “The president provided them (young generation) such things (drugs) along with food and alcohol. He took them to the big hotels. So, how can you win love? By drugs. You call it diplomacy or strategy but in our villagers’ language we call it “Gavgundi”.”
- The current president comes from the village’s dominant *bhauki*, and benefits from immense wealth and caste privilege. He contested against his rival *bhauki* leader, who is relatively less powerful.

- High *de facto* authority of president

- Male citizen 1: “Yes, the current president is from a powerful family. They only rule now. The president is on the front foot when it comes to both networking with big political leaders and Dadagiri.”
- Male citizen 2: “Now he takes all decisions. Villagers don’t get to know about anything. Whatever comes we listen and accordingly follow them. No one listens to us. The president clearly says, “What do you understand about this?”
- Village council clerk: “Only the president speaks in the village council. And others are silenced by pressure.”

F Survey experiment: Design, data, analyses

F.1 Sampling

2347 voters above the age of 18 were surveyed across 18 state assemblies in North Maharashtra. The survey used a stratified random sampling strategy for surveying voters. 100 voters from each of the 18 constituencies, and then an additional 340 voters in the 3 urban centers were sampled to ensure a balance of rural and urban voters; additional Dalit voters in the Bhusawal constituency and other constituencies were sampled, for a total targeted sample of 2347 voters. Within each constituency, one village or town was selected per 20 respondents, for a total of 4 to 6 sites per constituency, while for the urban centers, all the respondents are sampled in the same city. These sites are selected based on their ethnic composition and areas where grassroots organizations are active in voter mobilization. To achieve the stratified quota sample, a random walk method was employed where enumerators turn left when entering the area and survey every fourth individual until the desired gender and ethnic quota within the location is met. No payment was provided for participation in the survey. The survey took place from late August 2024 to mid October 2024.

The survey included several experimental modules after pre-treatment covariates. The order of the experimental modules – and thus of the experimental module of interest in this study – was randomized to avoid order effects.

F.2 Experimental design

The experiment features a vignette of a hypothetical village president, where the gender and caste of the president vary, with two possibilities each (2x2 factorial design). Participants are randomly assigned using simple randomization (with equal probabilities of assignment to condition) to 1 of 4 conditions, displayed in Table F.1 below.

Table F.1: Experimental conditions

Condition	Gender	Caste
1	Female	Maratha (Dominant)
2	Male	Maratha (Dominant)
3	Female	Dalit (Non-dominant)
4	Male	Dalit (Non-dominant)

In particular, gender of the president was manipulated using she/her or he/him pronouns combined with an obviously female (Bharti) or male (Rohit) first name in this context. Caste of the president was manipulated using surnames with obvious caste connotations in this context: Marathe (Maratha) or Kamble (Dalit). Three other dimensions are kept constant: the age of the president (the mean age of the president sample from the previous study), the fact that the village is numerically dominated by Marathas, and the amount of time for which the president has been in office (1 year). The vignette wording (in English: the surveyed version is in Marathi or Hindi, depending on the respondent’s preferred language) is as follows, with words in brackets varying according to the experimental condition.

Now, I'll tell you about the president of a village council here in Maharashtra. I'm interested in your opinions about this president. [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] is a 42-year old [female/male] president. [She/he] is a [Maratha/Dalit] president, in a village where more than half of people are Maratha. [She/he] has been the president of the village council for one year.

Based on your experience and knowledge of the way village councils work in reality on the ground, what type of experience do you think [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] will have?

F.3 Outcomes

Three outcomes of interest – authority, pliability, and backlash – are collected directly on the screen following the experimental vignette. I detail them below, as well as how I code them based on responses.

1. Authority.

- **Question:**

- Imagine there are some important decisions to be made in the village. As you probably know, sometimes other people – influential people in the village, village elders, other council members, or family members – step in and take village decisions in the place of the president or are generally more active than the president. Sometimes however it is the case that the president is the most influential actor. In this village, do you think that a president like [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] would be the one who is the most active in taking village decisions, or do you think it would be someone else?

- **Response options:**

- President
- Someone else

- **Coding:**

- President = 1, Someone else = 0

2. Pliability (propensity to resign).

- **Question:**

- As you probably know, in almost every village, there are generally some influential people when it comes to village affairs, for example a chawri group, or bhauki leaders. Imagine that influential people in this village ask [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] to resign from their post as president. Do you think that a president like [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] would accept this request and resign, or would [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] resist the request?

- Response options:
 - Resign
 - Resist
- Coding:
 - Resign = 1, Resist = 0

3. Backlash.

- Question:
 - Now imagine that [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] becomes quite powerful as a president. [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] makes [her/his] own decisions about what is best for the village, which are not always in line with what the influential villagers want, and [she/he] refuses to resign from [her/his] position as president. Do you think that [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] would likely face backlash from influential people in the village? For example, threats, bullying, or violence?
- Response options:
 - Yes, it is likely
 - No, it is not likely
- Coding:
 - Yes = 1, No = 0

F.3.1 Covariates and balance

In this appendix, I report balance for the following covariates: locality (urban vs. rural), age, gender, religion, caste, education, prior voter participation, self-reported knowledge on local politics, and a gender norms indicator. These are the covariates that I will include in my regression models.

The covariates are coded as follows:

- Locality (rural area): Factor variable with two levels: Village and Nagar palika or Mahanagar palika.
- Age: continuous variable.
- Gender: Factor variable with two levels: Male, female.
- Religion: Factor variable with seven levels: Hindu, Muslim, Christian, Buddhist, Sikh, Adviasi, and Jain. This is subject to adjustment based on the sample demographics.
- Caste: Factor variable with six levels: Adivasi, Dalit, OBC, Maratha, VJNT, and other general caste. This is subject to adjustment based on the sample demographics.
- Education: Factor variable with three levels: Primary school or less, secondary school, undergraduate and above. This is subject to adjustment based on the sample demographics.
- Prior voter participation: Factor variable with two levels: voted in 2019 state elections or did not vote.
- Self-reported knowledge on local politics: Factor variable with two levels: Not knowledgeable at all or reports having some knowledge.
- Gender norms: The value given for the following question:
 - As per your understanding, approximately what percent (on a scale of 0 to 100) of the inhabitants in your locality think that it is appropriate that women vote? (on a scale of 0 to 100)

I present the proportion of voters and standard deviation for each covariate level across the four treatment groups in Table F.2. I assess balance in Table F.3 using F-tests of global significance for these covariates for each treatment group, via regressing each of the four treatment group indicators on these covariates, extracting the F-statistic, and its p-value. Failing to reject the null at the 5 percent level supports balance. I control for these covariates in my preferred specifications regardless of balance test results. Table F.3 reveals significant differences particularly for the Christian and Jain variable in predicting the Bharti Marathe and Rohit Marathe treatment conditions. This is due to the very small number of Christian ($n = 4$) and Jain ($n = 3$) respondents, none of whom, due to chance, were assigned to either of these conditions. I double-checked the randomization procedure in order to ensure successful randomization of the dominant caste attribute randomization.

Table F.3: Balance test

	Bharti Kamble	Bharti Marathe	Rohit Kamble	Rohit Marathe
Rural	0.019 (0.021)	-0.031 (0.021)	-0.004 (0.021)	0.017 (0.021)
Age	-0.001 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)
Gender	0.020 (0.018)	-0.030+ (0.018)	-0.039* (0.018)	0.049** (0.019)
religionBuddhist	0.084 (0.063)	-0.021 (0.066)	-0.050 (0.064)	-0.014 (0.066)
religionChristian	0.338 (0.282)	-0.282*** (0.058)	0.237 (0.287)	-0.293*** (0.057)
religionHindu	0.079+ (0.044)	-0.042 (0.049)	0.037 (0.046)	-0.074 (0.050)
religionJain	0.189 (0.342)	-0.309*** (0.058)	0.416 (0.354)	-0.296*** (0.057)
religionMuslim	0.065 (0.049)	-0.016 (0.054)	-0.003 (0.051)	-0.046 (0.055)
casteOBC	-0.066+ (0.036)	0.021 (0.033)	0.029 (0.033)	0.016 (0.033)
casteOther General Caste	-0.039 (0.045)	-0.011 (0.042)	0.066 (0.043)	-0.017 (0.044)
casteScheduled Caste (Dalit)	-0.076 (0.050)	0.035 (0.047)	0.075 (0.049)	-0.035 (0.047)
casteScheduled Tribe (Adivasi)	-0.069+ (0.041)	0.039 (0.038)	0.026 (0.037)	0.003 (0.038)
casteVJNT (Bhatke Vimukt)	-0.042 (0.110)	0.014 (0.108)	0.003 (0.098)	0.024 (0.104)
educationSecondary school	-0.036 (0.029)	0.048+ (0.028)	-0.040 (0.029)	0.028 (0.029)
educationUndergraduate and above	-0.033 (0.035)	0.042 (0.034)	-0.027 (0.034)	0.017 (0.034)
prior _{vote} Yes	0.010 (0.026)	-0.036 (0.026)	0.015 (0.025)	0.011 (0.025)
Knowledge of local politics	0.001 (0.029)	0.007 (0.029)	0.004 (0.028)	-0.012 (0.030)
Gender norms	0.001 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.001)
Num.Obs.	2359	2359	2359	2359
R2	0.007	0.008	0.009	0.007
F.statistic	0.917	12.792	1.039	20.059
F.p.value	0.558	0	0.411	0

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Each model is a linear regression of each treatment group indicator on covariates. All regressions use robust standard errors.

F.3.2 Pre-specified confirmatory hypotheses: Analyses

This Appendix presents analyses from six pre-specified confirmatory hypotheses, four main and two secondary. These are presented in Table F.4 below.

Table F.4: Pre-registered main and secondary hypotheses

	M1: Male advantage in authority		M2: Dominant caste advantage in authority		M3: Male advantage in pliability		M4: Dominant caste advantage in pliability		S1: Male advantage in backlash?		S2: Dominant caste advantage in backlash	
	Unadjusted	Covariate-adjusted	Unadjusted	Covariate-adjusted	Unadjusted	Covariate-adjusted	Unadjusted	Covariate-adjusted	Unadjusted	Covariate-adjusted	Unadjusted	Covariate-adjusted
Male	0.044*	0.049**	0.049**	0.139***	-0.038+	-0.042*	-0.100***	-0.099***	-0.004	-0.007	-0.113***	-0.114***
Maratha	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.020)	(0.019)	(0.020)	(0.019)	(0.021)	(0.020)	(0.020)	(0.020)
rural		0.029		0.031		0.030		0.028		0.106***		0.104***
		(0.023)		(0.023)		(0.023)		(0.023)		(0.024)		(0.023)
age		-0.002		-0.002		0.005***		0.005***		0.003**		0.003**
		(0.001)		(0.001)		(0.001)		(0.001)		(0.001)		(0.001)
gender		0.019		0.016		0.043*		0.045*		0.008		0.011
		(0.020)		(0.019)		(0.020)		(0.020)		(0.021)		(0.021)
religionBuddhist		-0.154*		-0.151*		-0.041		-0.041		0.010		0.006
		(0.065)		(0.065)		(0.069)		(0.068)		(0.071)		(0.074)
religionChristian		-0.036		0.041		-0.134		-0.187		0.272		0.207
		(0.254)		(0.259)		(0.222)		(0.226)		(0.309)		(0.309)
religionHindu		-0.116*		-0.102*		0.036		0.027		0.008		-0.004
		(0.049)		(0.047)		(0.050)		(0.049)		(0.055)		(0.054)
religionJain		0.202***		0.292***		-0.340***		-0.394***		-0.033		-0.103
		(0.056)		(0.059)		(0.074)		(0.064)		(0.324)		(0.324)
religionMuslim		0.080		0.086+		-0.031		-0.033		0.225***		0.218***
		(0.051)		(0.050)		(0.055)		(0.054)		(0.060)		(0.060)
casteOBC		-0.035		-0.037		0.081*		0.082*		-0.091*		-0.087*
		(0.038)		(0.038)		(0.038)		(0.037)		(0.039)		(0.039)
casteOther General Caste		0.013		0.019		0.133**		0.128**		-0.033		-0.035
		(0.045)		(0.045)		(0.048)		(0.048)		(0.050)		(0.050)
casteScheduled Caste (Dalit)		0.130*		0.132*		0.035		0.034		-0.112*		-0.111*
		(0.051)		(0.052)		(0.053)		(0.053)		(0.055)		(0.055)
casteScheduled Tribe (Adivasi)		-0.002		-0.005		-0.031		-0.029		-0.128**		-0.124**
		(0.044)		(0.043)		(0.042)		(0.042)		(0.044)		(0.044)
casteVJNT (Bhatke Ymukt)		0.098		0.095		0.284*		0.286*		-0.095		-0.091
		(0.099)		(0.100)		(0.124)		(0.124)		(0.115)		(0.116)
educationSecondary school		0.118***		0.107***		0.026		0.034		-0.064*		-0.056+
		(0.031)		(0.031)		(0.031)		(0.031)		(0.032)		(0.032)
educationUndergraduate and above		0.094*		0.085*		0.022		0.029		-0.046		-0.040
		(0.037)		(0.036)		(0.037)		(0.037)		(0.039)		(0.039)
knowledge $geopolitics$		0.011		0.011		-0.071*		-0.071*		0.036		0.036
		(0.029)		(0.029)		(0.033)		(0.033)		(0.033)		(0.033)
gender $norms$		-0.002**		-0.002**		0.003***		0.002***		-0.001*		-0.001*
		(0.001)		(0.001)		(0.001)		(0.001)		(0.001)		(0.001)
Num.Obs.	2347	2341	2347	2341	2347	2341	2347	2341	2346	2340	2346	2340
R2	0.002	0.057	0.025	0.076	0.002	0.038	0.011	0.047	0.000	0.048	0.013	0.061

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001
Each model is a linear regression of each treatment indicator (either male or Maratha) on each outcome, corresponding to each hypothesis. For each hypothesis, unadjusted and covariate-adjusted estimates are presented. All regressions use robust standard errors.

G External validity

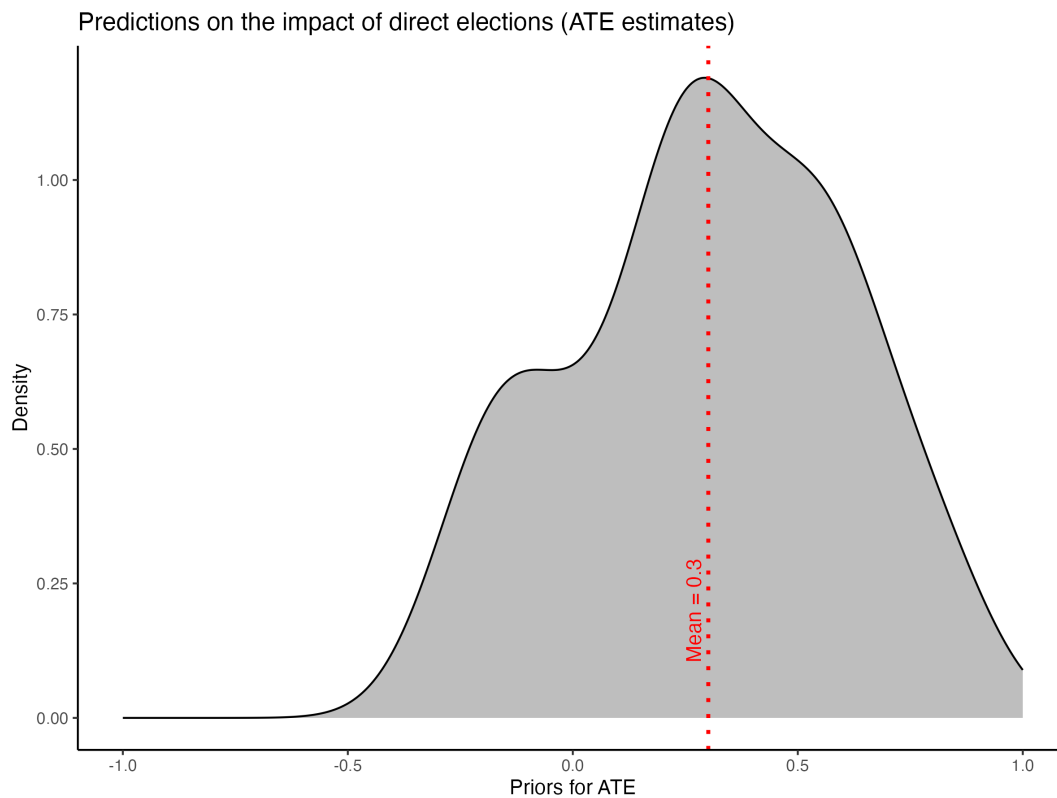
At the International Electoral Affairs Symposium organized by the State Election Commission of Rajasthan, I both collected expert priors about the impact of direct elections at the local level and interviewed election experts (State Election Commissioners and other election officials from across India) more holistically about their state's experiences with direct and/or indirect elections. Drawing on these two sources of data, this Appendix reasons about the impact of direct elections outside of the case studied in this paper (Maharashtra).

G.1 Expert predictions

This Appendix documents expert predictions about the impact of direct elections collected on July 25, 2024 in Jodhpur, India. The priors were collected from 34 election officials (including State Election Commissioners, Deputy Election Commissioners, Commission Secretaries) representing 9 Indian states and Union Territories.

In the prediction elicitation exercise, I first underscored the difference between indirect and direct elections for the president position at the local level, though all participants were already familiar with the institutional rules through their work. Second, participants were given and read aloud the prompt: “Imagine: On average, indirect presidents have an “authority” score of 20 %. On average, what would be the authority score of directly elected presidents?” They were prompted to ask clarifying questions and discuss among themselves if they so desired. When ready, they entered their predictions for the authority of the directly elected president (relative to the indirectly elected president) on their mobile phones via a mobile data collection application. Figure G.1 below plots these expert predictions, which were calculated via subtracting 20 (the fixed, average indirect president authority score) from the score the expert entered, to construct the predictions for the ATE of direct elections on authority. To put the scale in terms of the authority measures used in this paper (0-1), I divide the ATEs by 100.

Figure G.1: Expert predictions on the impact of direct elections on president’s authority



Note: This graph plots the density plot of expert predictions of the impact of direct elections on authority.

Figure G.1 show that, by and large, election experts predict large, positive effects of direct election on executive strength. The mean prediction for the ATE is 0.3, or a 30 percentage point increase in authority relative to indirectly elected presidents. This largely conforms to the conventional wisdom about direct elections ushering in “strong” local executives.

G.2 Qualitative evidence from across India

I also interviewed several senior election officials from across the subcontinent about their views on the impact of (in)direct elections, through their direct experience administering elections. I briefly summarize the takeaways from these conversations here. A senior election official from Andhra Pradesh, for instance, shared that indirect presidents have historically been “pushed around too much,” according to his observations. The head bureaucrat of the West Bengal Election Commission, where president elections are indirect, stated that indirectly elected presidents typically face pressure from elite factions. These observations are in line with the idea that indirectly elected presidents face challenges to their *de facto* authority. In contrast, senior election officials from Jammu and Kashmir expressed that, in their experience, direct elections bring in “big men” into the president position. One official stated that typically these “influential people” like contractors, old presidents, businessmen and landowners are the ones who win the direct president elections. Similarly in Himachal Pradesh, the direct election of presidents has witnessed, as a senior official noted, auctions of the president seat to the highest elite bidder. These observations are in line with this paper’s expectations, where direct elections usher in members of the elite who firmly command political institutions from within. In all, I take these insights from election experts across India as suggestive evidence that the theoretical expectations of this paper may hold in contexts outside of the one studied in this paper.

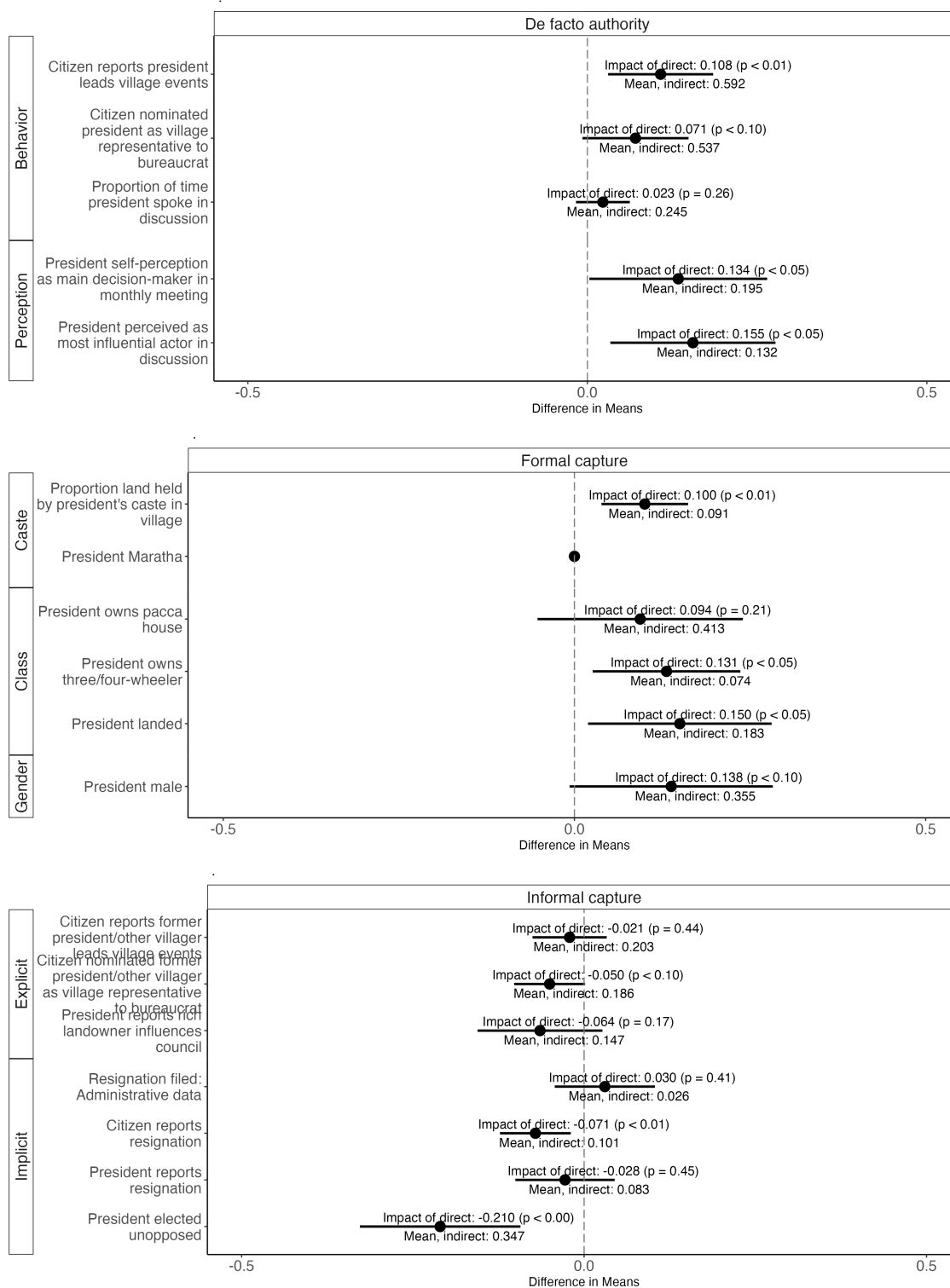
H Is there a way out? SC quotas and direct elections

This section provides three types of evidence that probe whether SC quotas, when they overlap with direct elections, may empower the local executive while rupturing elite capture of political institutions. First, I leverage the quasi-experimental observational design to explore whether SC presidents, when they are directly elected, experience increased *de facto* authority and decreased informal capture, while coming from outside of entrenched elite circles. Second, I analyze the survey experimental data to explore whether hypothetical SC presidents are more likely than their Maratha counterparts to be expected to face backlash when they become powerful. Third, I draw on controlled case comparisons between directly and indirectly elected SC-reserved villages to trace the processes of directly elected SC president empowerment and elite backlash.

H.1 Quasi-experimental observational analysis

Using the survey and administrative data employed for the observational analyses in the main paper, this section investigates the impact of direct elections on *de facto* authority, formal capture, and informal capture among SC-reserved president seats. Figure H.1 shows these analyses. Three suggestive findings emerge (these analyses are suggestive and underpowered due to the small N, with 194 village councils having SC-reserved seats in the survey data). First, SC-reserved presidents enjoy a *de facto* authority boost when elected directly. Second, SC-reserved presidents, by virtue of their reservation status, do not come from Maratha caste groups; they are also not clearly more likely to be men (this analysis is inconclusive as the point estimate is positive, but imprecisely estimated). However, directly elected SC-reserved presidents are more likely to benefit from class privilege, as is the case with most politicians on a global scale. Finally, evidence suggests that directly elected SC presidents are less likely to face some forms of informal capture, but these effects are imprecisely estimated so remain exploratory and suggestive.

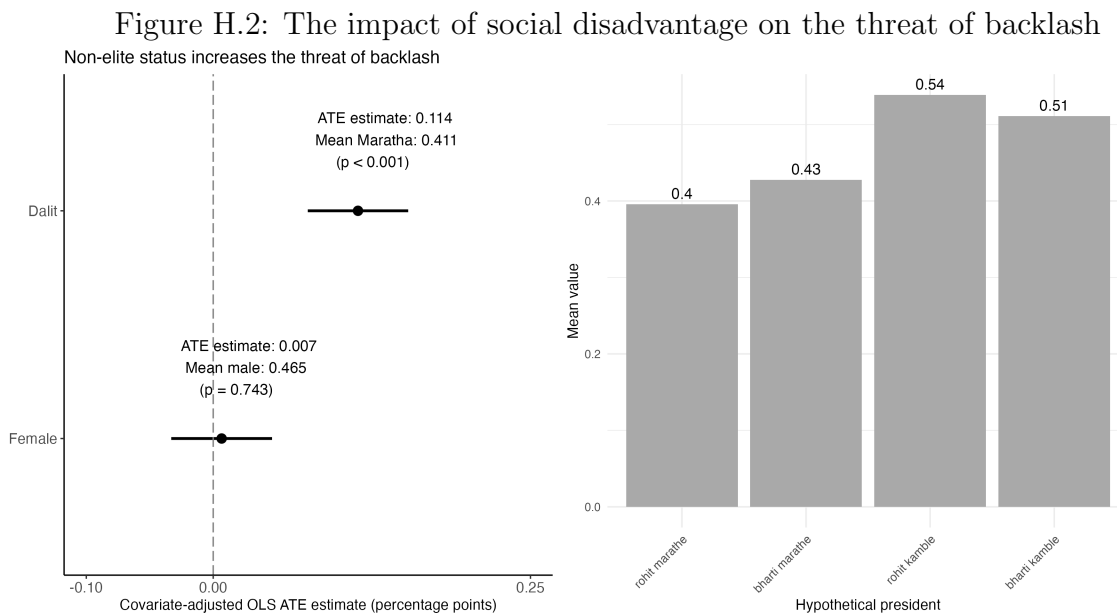
Figure H.1: The impact of direct elections in SC-reserved seats



Note: These graphs plot the impact of direct elections on outcomes among SC-reserved president seats. All specifications use robust standard errors. Citizen-based outcomes cluster at the village council level.

H.2 Survey experimental analysis

As was analyzed in the main paper, I draw here on the vignette survey experiment to test whether SC presidents are more likely than Maratha presidents to be expected to face backlash from important villagers. Below, Figure H.2 presents the results of this analysis, which focuses on respondent’s answers to the question: “Now imagine that [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] becomes quite powerful as a president. [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] makes [her/his] own deciions about what is best for the village, which are not always in line with what the influential villagers want, and [she/he] refuses to resign from [her/his] position as president. Do you think that [Bharti/Rohit] [Marathe/Kamble] would likely face backlash from influential people in the village? For example, threats, bullying, or violence?” If the respondent said “Yes, it is likely” the variable is coded as 1, and if they said “No, it is not likely” then it is coded as 0.



Note: Left panel reports two covariate-adjusted regressions of president gender and caste status on backlash measure. Right panel reports means of backlash by experimental condition. Backlash variable is binary: 1 if the respondent reports the president would likely face backlash if she became powerful, 0 if the respondent reports that the president would not likely face backlash in such an instance.

The analyses reveal that hypothetical Dalit presidents are significantly more likely to be expected to face backlash than their Maratha counterparts. While Maratha presidents are predicted to face backlash around 41 percent of the time, this number raises to about 53 percent for Dalit presidents. This conforms to the theoretical expectations in the main paper, that a threat to elite dominance (via empowered SC presidents making autonomous decisions) likely comes with a threat of elite backlash.

H.3 Qualitative evidence

H.3.1 Case comparisons

I report evidence from three controlled case comparisons (two direct villages, one indirect village) in SC-reserved village councils.

Village council 5. Village council 5 (indirect, SC reserved) showed explicit signs of informal capture through: pre-election coordination in temple meetings and post-election influence from local elites. The socially subordinate council president exhibited low levels of *de facto* authority, while unelected elites made decisions in her place.

- Pre-election coordination:
 - Citizen 1: “What you said about controlling power in few hands, resulted into opposed elections. In the past, almost all elections were unopposed...”
 - President: “Yes, Aba is Maratha, and his bhauki is [name removed]. In this village, there is a lot of [name removed]’s influence.”
 - Citizen 2: “We make this decision [about who will contest elections] within the Bhauki. If I get a chance this time, then the next time, someone else should get the chance. [When elections occur], we have meetings. Our Bhauki only meets at home, but other meetings are organised in temple.”
 - Clerk: “When an election is approaching, [the bhauki leaders] look for someone who hasn’t yet had a chance or who has performed well – they don’t just nominate anyone. There are those who provide guidance, giving direction on where things are going. They’re different individuals. But I can’t tell you their names. They don’t do this at the temple anymore. But I hope you understood that every major decision is made by different leaders.”
 - Female citizen 1: “Only one opposed [the president election], and the others were forced to step back. They were forced to withdraw their forms.”
- Post-election elite influence:
 - Male citizen 1: “Currently, there are bad people in power... I mean those who have committed crimes like murder... they feel the village should stay under their control.”
 - President: “Aba’s nature is really good. Whatever may be the work, whether there’s work to be done in Mumbai or Pune, he manages everything. He does it personally. I don’t attend because, with my blood pressure and sugar levels, there’s no point in creating trouble. And these youngsters might say, “If she can’t handle her health why does she come?” Otherwise, I even had a chance to go to Delhi as Sarpanch, but I didn’t go [he went].”
 - President: “Yes, Aba [supports me]. If I can’t come due to health issues, they say, “The elder lady can’t come this far; let’s manage the work ourselves and get her signature.” Aba handles all the main tasks... Aba’s support is invaluable. When I became Sarpanch, he treated me like a mother, and from that day, he’s

taken care of me as a mother. The young boys manage most of the tasks because they're full of energy, unlike me."

- Female citizen 1: "[Aba is] involved in politics... Earlier, he looked after all village matters... he wants things his way. He always expects that we all should give him importance and ask everything to him."
- Several framed photographs in the village council building featured Aba (village kingmaker) standing front and center, despite not being a member of the current council.

- Low *de facto* authority of president:

- Male citizen 1: "The current sarpanch is just for the sake of name... Like you said, the kingmaker does [the work of the sarpanch]... Look, if it's the three of us, the kingmaker would know which of us would stay in his control. He figured that an older woman wouldn't go anywhere; she'll just sign wherever she's told, so everything stays under his control."
- Male citizen 2: "The current Sarpanch is my nephew...Abaji." [Abaji is the 'kingmaker' in the village, but not the current sarpanch.]
- Female citizen 1: In response to the question "Is the current president able to influence members?" she responded "Not at all."

Village council 6. On the other hand, pre-election coordination among elites broke down in village council 6 (direct, SC-reserved). Instead, an independent SC candidate competed against other elite-backed candidates and won. The president commanded significant *de facto* authority once in office. However, the president faced several instances of elite backlash.

- Independent SC candidate wins

- President: "because of my son [the desire to contest elections] desire started forming, and then the opportunity came. Since I hadn't studied enough, I never had these kinds of dreams [previously]... There's a difference between a sarpanch elected by members and one elected by the people. I feel it is different... Now, with direct elections, even if seven people demand resignation, and the president doesn't want to, the position won't go... Before, most of the decisions [were] made outside. These outside people told the body what to do, and the body only did that much."
- President: "The whole village supported us during the campaign." However, other candidates contested the election against the president. "Those 4 [influential] people manipulated our family members who opposed us [in the elections]." In other words, the *bhauki* leaders put up opposing candidates to the president.

- High *de facto* authority of president

- President: "No, I won't resign. Even if someone tries to pressure me, I won't resign. If I were elected through the members, then maybe I would have."

- Influential citizen 1: “But if the Sarpanch is directly elected by the people, the influence of the influential people or key decision makers in the bhauki definitely reduces.”
- Female citizen 1: “But now, by getting the post directly, [the president has] become confident enough to speak. This is actually a good change, that everyone gets equal rights and opportunities.”
- Instances of elite backlash
 - President: “Yes, such [influential] people are there. We have about 4-5 of them in our village. And some [of them] don’t like that we came directly through the people or the SC reservation... Yes, we receive calls too, but we aren’t afraid.”
 - Influential citizen 1: “In our village, it’s the Sarpanch who troubles us...Not just because she is a woman, but because, being Dalit, she has certain legal rights, like those under the Atrocity Act and others. Tomorrow, if we point out any wrongdoings, she could file a police complaint against us, not allowing us to work. Being a woman is a plus point, and being Dalit is a bonus. So, no one can say anything. Democracy has been undermined by Dalit dictatorship now.”

Village council 7. Similar to village council 6, pre-election coordination among elites broke down in village council 7 (direct, SC-reserved). Instead, an independent SC candidate competed against other elite-backed candidates and won. The president commanded significant *de facto* authority once in office. However, the president faced several instances of elite backlash.

- Independent SC candidate wins
 - Female citizen 1: “Until now, members from that household have always won. There was a dispute over this because others wanted a chance, but they didn’t allow it. Now, if he stands for direct election, no one will vote for him because people are fed up with their family always winning... When [the current president contested] they opposed her. They oppose everyone. See, this village in their control for so many years. Previously his uncle was there for 20 years, then his aunt, then his mother... School committee president should hoist the flag in the school and sarpanch in the gram panchayat. But always, someone from Nilesh’s family used to hoist the flag. But this time, president was different, so unanimously we didn’t oppose him. Every year, there was the convention that outside flag will be hoisted by up-sarpanch and inside by the sarpanch. Every year, someone from his family used to hoist the flag. But this time people on the committee changed, so the conflict occurred... Lot of conflict happened. He (Nilesh) wants every position to his family. He said to me once, “you are respected only because of me.”
 - Male citizen 1: “The method where the Sarpanch is directly elected by the people is better. Earlier, it used to be that whoever had influence, his man used to be sarpanch. Yes, that’s how it used to be. But now, the Sarpanch receives votes from the entire village directly.”

- Influential person 1: In speaking about the president contesting against other candidates, the respondent stated, “Yes, we [the influential leaders] suggested dividing the term among them: two years for the first person or for the last, and 1.5 years for the other two. But they didn’t listen. Then he (Nilesh) fielded one candidate for their wada... to oppose her. But the other two lost and only she won.”
- Male citizen 2: “The influential people did not back the president in the election... they opposed her a lot. But because her intentions were good, she gained the village’s support, and people voted for her... The influential people found her ideals difficult to accept. They felt that if someone they could control had come to power, they would be able to maintain their influence because they could pressure her to do as they said.”
- High *de facto* authority of president
 - Female citizen 1: “[The current president] is very good... she did a lot of improvement in her area over five years... There was no water supply in her area, but [the president] brought water. There was no street light, so she installed solar lights.”
 - Male citizen 2: “[since the] president is elected directly by the people, she holds the role for five years, and she can manage things properly. She can keep track of funds and projects... [the president] faced trouble, but a lot of development also took place.”
 - Female citizen 2: “[The president] has very good behavior and calmly handles any problem that comes up.”
- Instances of elite backlash
 - Female citizen 1: “they pressured her...People won’t say anything because if such things reaches to them, it could escalate.”
 - Male citizen 2: “[The harassment of the president] happens in this village... I can be straightforward. If anyone from a particular caste [understood as SC] is [president], they are not given the respect they deserve... If there’s a program in the village temple and the president, who happens to be a woman, goes there, she’s sometimes not allowed to perform the aarti (ritual offering)... Their close associates or supporters do the rituals instead.”
 - President: “I never had any issues with the members. But, yes, some people in the village do create issues.”

I Ethical considerations

	Survey and qualitative data	Qualitative and administrative data	Survey experimental data
Method	In-person interviews	In-person interviews and administrative data collection	In-person interviews (survey)
Dates	2018-2022	2022-2025	August-October 2024
Implementation	Author and RA from local research institute; Across Research and Communication Private Limited (India-based survey firm)	Author and RA from local research institute	Author-trained enumerator team
Consent	Author or enumerators read an IRB-approved oral consent form, and proceeded with the interview only if the interviewee voluntarily consented to participate in the study.	Author read IRB-approved oral consent form, and proceeded with the interview only if the interviewee voluntarily consented to participate in the study.	Enumerators read an IRB-approved oral consent form, and proceeded with the interview only if the interviewee voluntarily consented to participate in the study.
Compensation	None	None	None
No Deception	None	None	None
Ethics Review	Approved by BU IRB: protocol 5432X.	Approved by UC Berkeley IRB: protocol 2022-04-15307.	Approved by Harvard University IRB: protocol 24-0241.